From:rbarnesrol@aol.com

To:rbarnesrol@aol.com

Tue, Oct 19, 2021 at 8:12 PM

From: rbarnesrol@aol.com
To: rbarnesrol@aol.com
Sent: 10/19/2021 8:11:50 PM Eastern Standard Time
Subject: book 8 11 pm 10 19

The Sheep who became a Shepherd

In 1946 unmarried, eighteen year old Mary Magdelene awaiting the birth of her first child, me.

Mary pretended to be in California when in fact she was on the SE side of Grand Rapids making sure her parents and church located on the NW side of town would never find out that out she had gotten pregnant. The only family member she told was her sister, Helen , who was also pregnant at that time. Helen married the baby's father. Mary

Mary, was a daughter of Lithuanian immigrants living in an ethnic and religious neighborhood filled with those from that same country. Her uncle was the parrish priest. Her secrecy was motivated by a desire to protect the family name, she did not want to bring shame to her family.

In 1946 being an unmarried mom was rare; the negative stigma was brutal.

The twenty seven year old father of the baby , a tall, handsome man named Earnest Arthur Hoyt, was the son of a Methodist preacher. Usually know by everyone as "Blackie" and sometimes "Arthur", he was a mixture of English and Dutch who was of a darker complexion than most of his ethnicity.

Although he was from a law abiding, Christian family, he had chosen to be a rebel. In addition to his frequent womanizing, he had chosen to become a criminal.

Mary knew that to marry him would be foolish.

Maty tried a few of the “old wife’s tale” methods to abort the pregnancy. None worked.

Turning to a fortune teller for advice, the occult practicioner told her that every person needs a channel through which to enter the world and strongly suggested that she allow herself to be that channel.

Mary decided to birth me.

She asked Dr. Ruis (lu) to look into the adoption procedure for me.

Dr. Ruis was in Burton Heights in walking distance from the apartment that Blackie had suggested to her which she shared with his friend, Roberta Smith.

My adopted parents , Floyd and Cora Herms from Byron Center and Mary shared this same doctor. The doctor asked them whether they wanted to adopt another child. They eagerly said, “Yes”! They did not know if I would be a boy or girl as they had to wait through the pregnancy to find out.

My adopted parents had already adopted 2 children. June was two and a half; my brother, Carl , was had just turned seven when I arrived in their home at 8368 Byron Center Ave on 9 27 1946.

Mary had kept me with her for ten days after I had been born on her kitchen table. During that time Arthur came to see me. She told me that one day he took some friends with him to see me and they passed me around the room like a “sack of potatoes”. Years later, in the basement of Cal and Loie Bergsma’s home home in a Bible Study there, Cal was ministering to heal “deep hurts”. I saw an inner vision of me being passed around in Mary’s apartment that day. In my vision as they were handing me around the circle, the Lord Himself came in the room and took me to my parents’ home. Later when I told my dad, about this vision, he (being orphaned and then adopted at age 5) told me the Lord had given him the verse: **Psalm 27:10 kjv**[10] When my father and my mother forsake me, then the LORD will take me up. That verse is an immense comfort to me!

As I share my story, know that I refer to Mary and Blackie as my birth mom and dad. When I say “Mom” or “Dad”, I am referring to my adopted parents. The Herms are the ones who took me in , loved me, gave me all that I need, and will forever hold the place of honor given to a parent. Although I deeply loved Mary and often even felt with her like a daughter, I remained loyal to make the distinction between my “birth mom” and my “mom”.

On September 27, 1946 I was taken by Dr. Ruis to my new home. When I arrived my new sister said to mom, “Now you have a Rosemary and I have a Rosemary”. June’s doll’s name was “Rosemary”. The name became mine. My full new name became Rosemary Lois Barnes.

My cousin, Mary Berkompas Vander Ark, told me just a few years ago that she was there when I arrived and she has shared with me the joy present at that occasion. She is the only one still alive who was present that day and I was happy to be able to talk with her about it!

Childhood experiences:

I got mono in the 8th grade and mom would not let me try out for chekerleading. That lead me ot debate and also many music situations: band, pepe band, marching band, choir, senior trio, honors quartet, Michigan honors choir, sailorettes

When I was nineteen I was a detention group worker at Kent County Juvenile Court. I told my supervisor I had been adopted. He told me I could probably find my records in the court files. At that time our supervisors were also responsible on the eleven to seven shift to go into the court side from time to time as a security measure. So one night he took me in there. Apparently they only kept those records at that time until the adoptee reached twentyone because I wanted to look up June and Carl too but those records were not there. Mine was.

The paper I looked at said my birth mom's name was Mary Magdeline Rinkus and that she had named me Roberta Maria Rinkus. Her mom and dad's name were Casimer and Rose Rinkus.

I have written how I got the name "Rosemary". But the fact is that my parents had no idea what my mom or her mom's name was. I was impressed by the Lord's fingerprints on my name. Birth mom is "Mary"; her mom is "
Rose".

Because my birth dad was such a notorious criminal, Mary made up a ficticious name when the form requested the father's name. She chose the name "Robert Church". In January of 1980 my husband Robert and I started our church, Grand Rapids River of Life Ministries. Again, I saw God's fingerprints on my destiny.

. The song is “For Those Tears I Died”. You can search online for the melody and lyrics. The main thought is that You said You'd come and share all my sorrows,
You said You'd be there for all my tomorrows;
I came so close to sending You away,
But just like You promised You came there to stay;
I just had to pray!

Your goodness so great I can't understand,
And, dear Lord, I know that all this was planned;
I know You're here now, and always will be,
Your love loosed my chains and in You I'm free;
But Jesus, why me?

Jesus said, "Come to the water, stand by My side,
I know you are thirsty, you won't be denied;
I felt ev'ry teardrop when in darkness you cried,
I strove to remind you that for those tears I
died."

Jesus, I give You my heart and my soul,
I know that without God I'd never be whole;
Savior, You opened all the right doors,
And I thank You and praise You from earth's humble
shores;
Jesus I'm Yours.

Jesus said, "Come to the water, stand by My side,
I know you are thirsty, you won't be denied;
I felt ev'ry teardrop when in darkness you cried,
And I strove to remind you that for those tears I
died."

Until I saw these legal papers at Juvenile Court, I was always very curious about my racial makeup.

When I was in high school I kept nagging my parents about whether the doctor told them anything about that. Finally mom said she had a vague memory of the doctor saying the

mother was something that sounded like . But she was really uncertain whether she heard it right. I immediately looked up Hungary in the encyclopedia. Being dark complected , like I later discovered Blackie to be, had produced a lot of speculation both within myself and from others about what I might be! After a hair permanent in 6th grade one girlfriend called me the "n" word. Yes, that word specifically. And, I actually wondered if maybe I had some African blood in me.

In the muck fields when I was 12 I worked along side the Mexicans wondered if I was Mexican. I comfortably related to them and they called me "Bonita Rosa Maria". That birth paper said my grandparents had immigrated to Grand Rapids from Lithuania. Lithuania? I never heard of that country. Of course at that time Lithuania was Baltic country that had become a part of the Soviet Union. I had wasted a lot of time thinking I was Hungarian! I remembered when the Koscundy family showed up from Hungary at South Christian High School in the early '60's and wondered if I had missed getting to know some of "my people" while in high school still now knowing for sure what I was.

Many years later I realized what a blessing it had been to not know my race for nineteen years. I had imagined the possibility of being so many different races that I had learned to just fit in with everyone just in case they were "my people". I then arrived at the place where it just did not matter to me what anyone's race was . I related closely with people simply based on their reception of me and mine of them. I remain that same way today.

Where I was raised was very ethnocentric. The community I was adopted into was Dutch, Christian Reformed, and politically conservative. Technically the general rule was that we should not even have close friends who were not Christian Reformed and not in a Christian School. Unthinkable was the idea that we would date out of our race!

Furthermore, the women all around me were very proper . Very few had an "outside

career" The vast majority were were wonderful, hard working homemakers.

I heard very few (if any) strong opinions from women's mouths. Women "let" the men be the mouth pieces at our church in important meetings.

Men could gather immediately outside of the church after service and light up a cigarette. (That was before it was proven that there was a connection with tobacco and cancer so no one thought it was wicked to smoke.) They would form conversational circles and smoke together. I instinctively knew (and witnessed) that those circles were not to be entered by a woman and that a woman was not to smoke.

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A woman was never to make a "show of herself". Women did not draw attention to themselves with "loud" or "suggestive" clothing. If the choice between red or pink, royal blue or baby blue presented itself, we most often went with the pastels rather than the primary colors. Even the smell of perfume was understated.

To show emotion during church services was just not done. The Dutch in my community were disciplined in their use of emotional expression.

I remember one time when I was around ten years old thinking I would burst with joy when we sang "When we've been there ten thousand years, bright shining as the sun, We've no less days to sing God's praise, than when we've first begun". I subdued myself because when I looked around for any sign of emotion on the other faces , I found none. That moment has forever been etched in my memory as a time I knew I did not "fit" in that environment. I desired to communicate with all of my being – body, soul, and spirit.

What I did find in my culture in Byron Center were sincere, devout, loving Christians manifesting the fruit of the Spirit through their faithfulness and good deeds. I did deeply appreciate that.

However, by the time I passed through puberty at ten years old, I already simply knew that one day I would not be a part of the Dutch Christian Reformed culture and that I needed to live in a much bigger place than Byron Center. Without knowing the word "diversity", I was longing for an environment with all different kinds of people – people who could relate to all ethnic groups, people who would enjoy others who wanted to express themselves freely. And I had already made an inner vow that I would be a woman with a good job to support myself fully and never have to ask any man for money to buy a pair of nylons (now known as pantyhose and seldom worn by many women). I had envisioned already where I was headed.

Because of mom's desire for me to become a Christian School teacher, for many years

that was what I assumed I would become one day.

At three I do remember saying I would become a missionary, a teacher, and have an orphanage. (The third one has yet to happen; but, we do faithfully support an orphan

I could go much deeper into the details of my "differentness" from where I was placed by the Lord Himself. I just wanted to write enough so that you would understand how liberated and vindicated I felt in my soul when I met my birth mom. When I met her I understood me.

I do want you to know too that I realize that my Herms family was a perfect placement for me. My destiny would include the use of all the excellent teachings I got from my Christian Reformed pastors, the chapel services from the Christian grade school, the Christian High School , and from Calvin, and all the theology classes. The restrictions on my behavior were good for me as you will clearly see when I strayed into becoming a "lost sheep" . I think of how much more lost I would be if my parents were not diligent in giving me strong Christian upbringing. Like the prodigal, I returned to where I knew there would be love, i.e., with the Lord and with His family.

Very soon after I read the birth paper, I went about the process of finding my birth mom.

I assumed my birth mom was probably married . Of course her married name was not on the form. I went to the phone book to see if I could find my grand parents in there. There were only a few listings for "Rinkus". The first Rinkus I called was Mary's mom. I told her I would like the phone number of her daughter , Mary. Without hesitation she

gave it to me. Then I called Mary.

I had not thought of what I would say if she answered the phone. When Mary answered all I could think to say was, “Hi, I was born on 9 17 46.” There was silence, what seemed like a long pause, and then “Oh my God!”. We immediately made plans to meet. She told me later that she was skeptical of my motives in meeting her because my birth dad was into extortion and blackmail (along with his other long list of criminal specialties). She did not know that I could care less about anything but to become friends. Although she and her husband were considerably wealthier than my parents, I had no desire to attain their wealth level. Nor did I need her to be my new mom. I had excellent parents. They gave me all I needed. I simply wanted to get to know her.

Until then , all I ever dreamt about was meeting my birth mom. Mary had other daughters, four of them. She birthed six in all – me, a baby, Janie, who died immediately after birth, and four more, Lynn, Shelly, Karen, and Christie . In time I got to know and enjoy them all.

When I met her I was living in the first apartment I ever had on my own. There were three other girls who shared that apartment. It was in Grand Rapids on College NE just north of Michigan. Mary, now thirty nine years old, drove over to meet me there. The minute I got in her car I could not believe how amazingly familiar she felt to me. (How much bonding went on in those first ten days of my life? I often wonder.) She had on a summer sleeveless cotton dress of primary colors – red, royal blue, emerald green with a black back ground. She had on a very strong , fragrant perfume, Estee Lauder Youth Dew. She looked and smelled beautiful! She was made up to perfection. I was dazzled.

With Mary I did not feel “different”, she represented what I felt was inside of my soul waiting to blossom. She was nearly the opposite of what the women in my community were!

As time went on I saw that she was fearlessly outgoing to anyone she met. She had wigs and hair pieces of all colors and the corresponding makeup hues to harmonize with her chosen hair color of the day. She was a seamstress and sent for beautiful fabrics from all over to make exquisite clothing. She was a hairdresser by nature, no training , just natural ability to cut, color, and style hair. She was a great dancer. Mary took me to a local upscale clothing store in East Grand Rapids, Jacobson’s, and bought me a couple of beautiful outfits. She gave me a hairpiece. I closely imitated her make up style. She took me to her beautiful home and streaked my hair with blonde dye.

I got mixed reactions on that hair streaking . A guy who had been my “running buddy” at Calvin College took one look at me in my new outfit and hair color and declared his love for me and that he did not want to marry anyone else. (That relationship went into

“romance” briefly and then died – we should have stayed “buddies”.)

On the other hand, my parents took one look at me and refused to talk to me until I dyed it back to my “natural” color. My mom was strictly disciplined by her dad when she got a (forbidden) permanent as a teenager so I am thinking now that it was too big of a stretch-- considering her upbringing – for her to accept hair streaking.

Within days, I dyed my hair back to my “natural “ color. I was accepted by my parents again.

Since I was a little girl, mom called me “glamour puss” . I would experiment with my hair and with the little bit of makeup she owned. I always wondered why my pretty church clothes could not be worn to school too. Why could we not look and smell our best every day of the week? I wore Avon’s perfumes on the flat bed truck that took us to go to the muck farm where we would top onions or to gather into bunches the radishes. I also would cut other girls’ hair and still have an knack for “doing hair”.

The traits I write here are obviously pertaining to just the soul and the body as opposed to the more important realm of the Spirit; but, at that time these traits were valuable to me

as they seemed to express my own, separate identity which had been repressed for years.

Simply the concept of having a “separate identity” from those around me in Byron Center as a child and in my early teens resulted in my feeling as if I could not fit in to what seemed like a herd mentality of conformity . I remember watching the other girls on the playground wondering how they managed to all gather together and become friends. Now I realize surely there were others here and there who felt the same as I did. But then it seemed like I was alone in my state of mind.

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The occult:

Mary dabbled in reading palms, explaining identity through horoscopes, going to a fortune teller, and being open to other occult phenomena.

I also got fascinated with all things occult.

I read books by Edgar Cayce, Jean Dixon, and Arthur Ford. At that time, 1966, at the bookstores and the library there was very little written about the occult. Now whole stores are dedicated to the occult.

At the detention center at the Juvenile center we began to work the Ouiji Board together. It has what is called a “planchette”, a little plastic objective with a little “window’ that a

person can look through on the top of it. Two people would put there hands on this planchette. The actual board had letters on it. We would ask the board a question and then the planchette would begin to move around from letter to letter to spell out the answer.

It actually worked. One time the planchette was moving so rapidly we had to write the letters with no spaces and only could tell the message once the planchette stopped! While we had been playing the planchette a girl picked it up and kissed it because she was so thrilled with its responsiveness. When we separated the letters into words, one thing that was written was, "Don't kiss me, crack lip". We looked at her mouth and there was a crack on one of her lips . We had not noticed that until we saw that message.

One night on the three to eleven shift I decided to ask the board about my birth father. I had started to desire to meet him too. The Ouji board told me that I had a relative named "Assfy" living on Fulton and where the guy there was working. I went to the phone book in the worker office to see if I could find that name and address. Yes, it was there. I called the number asked the guy who answered if I could talk to him at his place after I got out of work. I showed up at around 11:30 PM. So eager was I to find out more about my paternal side that it never occurred to me how dangerous it was for me to go visit some stranger alone in his apartment in the evening! When I arrived I told him my story and he sat with me in his living room showing me pictures of his (and my?) family .

I still sit in complete surprise that he actually thought maybe what was happening was really true. He was a nice young man – it is sad we are not related and I never saw him again.

When I had asked Mary about my birth dad's identity she told me that she had too much to drink at a party and chose to go into a bedroom to just lay down and be quiet for awhile. Then some man whose identity she could not sort out in the dark came and laid there with her. He forced himself on her. Therefore, I was produced.

That was the story until I told her about my adventure on Fulton St. and how I was on the

path to learning about my paternal relatives. She seemed to realize how important to know was to me and what crazy things I might do to pursue answers. So she told me who he was.

Blackie was in the Kent County jail at that time. This fact had appeared in the Grand Rapids Press. I then went to the jail to visit him. He did not feel "familiar " to me. He did immediately accept me as his daughter. When he got out of jail he took me to see my Grandma Hoyt , a cousin, and some other relatives. He was very affectionate ; but, for whatever reason, I was hesitant to relate to him freely. I discerned some things that caused me to distrust him. But, I also loved him right away. He had me go to the bondswoman on Jefferson, Edith Rasberry, to get his briefcase he left with her. In this beautiful leather case was a picture of him and quite a bit of poetry he had written. I cherished that until much later when I went through some ignorance concerning transfer of demonic spirits. I was told and "fell for" the idea that I should destroy everything I got from him because of what could be spiritually inherited from a man like him. So I destroyed it. I now deeply regret that I did because I would love to reread the poetry and try to understand him better.

I did relate to him off and on until he died. I took my toddler son, E.G. , to meet him too.

He was in jail awaiting a trial when I met him. He met with Judge Vander Wal (before the trial) and told him that he found out he has a daughter and that fact had changed him. He vowed to the judge that he was ending his life of crime. That story actually appeared in the Grand Rapids Press! "Thief vows to end life of crime" was the title. In it was reported that "it is believed he learned he has a daughter". My name was not mentioned but I knew it spoke of me. Part of me wanted to believe him; part of me felt the reunion was being exploited.

The judge wanted to talk to me. In his office, with tears, he took out a letter his daughter had written to him and began to express to me how precious it is for a man to have a daughter. I was surprised that he opened his heart to me and even more surprised that it seemed he had no suspicion whatsoever that he might be being played by Blackie.

The sentence was lessened because of Blackie's vow .

I went to see him up north in Camp Cusino, a very low security prison. Still, I remained conflicted about relating to him.

Blackie had by then spent most of his adult life incarcerated . He had spent eight years

already at Jackson Prison .

He was free for awhile but later pulled another robbery and ended up in Jackson again where he died. He is buried there.

When he died, the Grand Rapids Press ran a story about him. He was called "one of Grand Rapids' most notorious criminals".

Blackie told me of various criminal activities he was involved in which included doing work for the mob. But I am unsure of what to believe from his testimonies. I did have a welfare client who did time in Jackson prison and knew Blackie. This man, my client, told me he once worked for Blackie doing his "strong arm" work for him. He said Blackie did not like "getting his hands dirty " doing that kind of work. I also had a friend, Rosemarie Lorge, who said her parents had a restaurant on S. Division that Blackie often went to. He offered to have their place burned down so they could collect the insurance money.

Blackie's daughter, my half sister, told me he used to come visit them with fancy cars, rolls of money, and a girlfriend on his arm while they lived very financially challenged.

Blackie told me he would get intimate with rich ladies so he could black mail them later.

Evidently he "diversified" his criminal activies.

I pulled back from him because I could not handle dealing with him. I could now. I regret I did not have the maturity or assertiveness to establish boundaries and to speak in love and in patience freely with him.

Even in the Grand Rapids Press the fact that he was known for his many women was included in the story. I read a court transcript about his theft ring within his business , "Grand Rapids Window Washing" which included the fact that he was married at the time but also kept a mistress in an apartment he was providing for her.

I will share an example that is troubling to me because it illustrates his duplicity: He told my half sister, Renee, that a young lady he brought to meet her was his daughter. Her name was Cynthia Merritt. I never met her but was told some facts. E.g., she had graduated from the University of Michigan. One day – years after I was told that she was my sister – I was getting dental work done at U of M 's dental school . I went to the alumni office services while I was there and asked if they had contact information on Cynthia. Their policy was to take my email address and then write to her to say I was looking for her. Soon she emailed me. I told her that Blackie said she was my sister. She wrote back and said she went around with him for a while but he was not her dad. I am

wondering even now: Why would he say she was his daughter?

Even in the Grand Rapids Press the fact that he was known for his many women was included in the story. I read a court transcript about his theft ring within his business , "Grand Rapids Window Washing" which included the fact that he was married at the time but also kept a mistress in an apartment he was providing for her.

If you are wondering if I can write something positive about him, here it is: In person he was warm, friendly, talkative, informative, and accepting . His voice and language were pleasing. He behaved as you would expect and educated gentlemen to behave. His appearance and dress were flawless. He was a man who, from outward appearance and the way he conducted himself , anyone would most likely accept and even favor. If all my contact with him was merely one on one meetings with no outside information as to what this man was capable of, I would have delighted in him and made sure we kept in contact. In spite of my ambivalence towards him, I did love him because he did immediately accept me as his daughter and proudly proceeded to introduce me to my grandma and to some other relatives.

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One dayMy birth mother took me to a fortune teller.On Turner South northwest in Grand Rapids, MI.This woman started her session was singing very traditional hymns about the blood of Jesus, and seemed to be a believer. Then she would take us alone into her bedroom and she would look somewhere on her wall.And say things like I get that you are going to and then she predicts something about our life. The fact is, everything she predicted about my life came true. This is one reason I knew EG was going to be a boy because she told me I was going to have a baby boy and this was long before I was.Never married.Uh.But what happened was right after I saw her, I went home, went to bed.And woke up sat up in the bed, looked at the wall just above the bedroom door and I saw a man.Looking back down at me he looked like an Indian man from India. I only saw his face almost like he was. It was a TV. It was a box and it was. His face was encased in glowing red and he was just looking at me peacefully kindly, seemingly and I knew.That that was a moment if I wanted to have the same spirit guide that this Evelyn Koning had, I

could choose to because he was inviting me to himself. Then I knew it was of the devil, because I knew that's not how the Lord operated to show up in some Indian.On the wall and I knew that to have gone to that fortune teller was not the right thing to do.

The reason I am writing some facts about my birth parents' choices is because later you will read about my own enormous need for deliverance from demons connected with birth and being given away. I know now that even in the womb we can get the spirits that influence our parents. I have often wanted to teach people considering adoption that they need to know that there may be some ministry and deep healing needs they may have to deal with!

Not only was Blackie's dad a pastor, but his Grandpa, James Muste, and another man started Bethany Reformed Church where Grandpa Muste was on the first board there, the church rector, and a Sunday School teacher. Blackie did hear the Word and did say he had been born again. I know today that he needed a huge amount of deliverance! I did present that thought to him once when I visited him in the Kent County Jail and he agreed. I have no idea if he did anything with that knowledge. He seemed to be more inclined to talk to God when he was incarcerated than when he was out. Because he died in prison, I am hoping that he went back to a relationship with God before he died. I am hoping I can see him again in eternity– it would be fun to enjoy talking with him without all the earthly issues he delved into lawlessly.

When he died there was and article in the Grand Rapids Press , “Death takes Blackie Hoyt”. His picture was there and the article said that he was one of Grand Rapids most notorious criminals.

One of the articles in the Press even stated that his IQ was measured at 132. Mine was too. I thought it peculiar that they included that detail. But, it did make me realize we had some connection after all.

Mary did not want me to know who my dad was because she knew what he was like. But, I am glad I met him. I have learned much about spiritual warfare that I can teach others because I have seen the damage done in lives when people are ignorant about the presence of demons.

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My adopted siblings and I all had times we deeply disappointed our parents through rebellion that brought shame to our family.

All three of us adopted into this blessed household rebelled. My brother was beloved by everyone but in his teens got in trouble. He stole five hundred dollars from his job at Lou DeJong’s grocery store where he was working and ended up a month in Jackson Prison and a couple of years at Cassidy Lake , a minimum security prison. Carl was brilliant and never had to study. He was good looking and fun loving. He worked faithfully with our dad in dairy dad owned, Floyd’s Dairy. When he got out he married a Catholic girl (already pregnant with my first niece, Debbie). My parents were heartbroken. In our circles dating or marrying a Catholic was another forbidden act.

Carl dropped out of church. The elders went to see him. He was disrespectful and non responsive to them. So – even though he dropped out (I don’t think he ever became a member through “Confession of Faith”)—they decided one Sunday morning to excommunicate him. I was sitting with day in the third row from the front when they turned to the back of our Psalter Hymnal to read the excommunication script . I do not remember anyone but Carl getting excommunicated ! I looked at dad and he was crying. I right now writing this am crying too. Dad got extremely hurt this public act towards Carl. Carl probaby did not care that they did that. And should have they done that to someone who never joined the church in the first place?

My sister, June, a quiet, painfully shy girl, was my mom’s kitchen helper. She was good at that . (I got placed in the dairy washing milk bottles and examining the eggs for clots. My ability to keep the kitchen tidy while I baked or cooked was not up to par with mom; June was neat).

June got pregnant when she was 15 by Melvin Fortuin. Mel was all set to marry her. I was going to be the maid of honor so I had my dress all ready. Mel’s dad, Chuck Fortuin

(lu spelling) , however, was adamantly against Mel marrying June! He offered 2,000.00 to his son to stop this marriage. June became a single mom. No support ever came from Mel. Terry, his son, looked just like him. (\

One day , years later, I called Mel. Terry was already married with kids. I wondered if Mel had any regrets and would he like to meet Terry. Mel denied even ever knowing a "June Herms". I was dumbfounded. He had been in our home many times . I had a picture of him on our porch. Yet he told this bold faced lie.

june After Terry was around 2 1/2 years old, my sister June did meet a nice man named.Archie Vandenbosch they got married.She had a four more children and seemed to settle into a.Nice life altogether. Before she died, I visit her home. I really thought to do that to ask her her salvation status with the Lord and she said she was a believer. I had been visiting my mum's grade, which I probably did twice.Ever since she died, which was decades ago, and when I was at her grave, I thought would be the best way to honor my mother. And I thought how happy she would be if I went and paid June of visits. That's why I went to her house in the first place. That wasn't long before her death.

At our church in Byron Center, like Mary's, to be pregnant and unmarried in the 1960's was to be a shame to your family and to your church. However, mom and dad received Terry with love. He lived with us for a couple years before she met her husband of many decades. I never once heard my parents suggest June give up Terry for adoption. Nor did I hear them say words of anger to her. Once we knew the baby was coming, the baby was welcomed and loved.

In 1966 my dad sold his business and my parents bought a home on Willard St. in Cutlerville. I was already commuting daily to Calvin College and had told them that I would be moving to Californnia once I graduated. Perhaps because of that declaration they did not really put a lot of thought into my settling into the new home for very long. I did not really ever make it my home in the way my Byron Center home was to me. Our childhood home was special to me in its entirety ; but, when my brother got married I got his room. I was so happy to not have to share a room with my sister anymore.

I announced to mom and dad my decorating plan for my new room. I painted all the furniture white myself; but, my folks hired someone to paint the room lavender. I was working at Grant's Lunchenette at Roger's Plaza at that time so I had some of my own money to spend in this bedroom. I bought a floor lamp, rugs, curtains, and other things to enhance the beauty in the room. They gave me a rocker which I painted and reupholstered to match the room. I spent many hours studying in that rocker.

The whole process of planning my colors and furniture placement opened up my soul to a latent talent: Decorating. That talent is shared with my birth mom and sisters. My

husband , Robert, is also deeply attracted to that activity. One of our date ideas is to go to furniture stores just to enjoy the ideas of decorators displayed in those stores. Looking at decorating magazines together is also our shared idea of a fun time.

My parent's had given me a record player . Because it was my room I could finally choose what to listen to! I bought many Christian Albums from Lanninga Electric . I also loved classical albums.

I just now realized more clearly the impact of the Lanninga family on my life: Mrs. Lanninga was my Sunday school teacher who would have us all to her house for dessert if we memorized all twentyone scripture verses she gave us. So I at around ten years old was sitting at their dining table in their apartment above their store eating cake one day because I accomplished (along with others) the memorization. It was the Lanninga's daughter, Ruth, who introduced me to my special friend, Loie Bergsma. It was the son in law . Sherwin Kamps, who was the last person to pray for me before I finally received the Holy Spirit Baptism. Sherwin and Ruth's daughter, Cathy Jo, was a vital part of the Madison Square Christian Reformed Church choir. She also had some wonderfully inspirational gatherings in recent years at her county home. The choir would fellowship around food and music.

I speak of these things to remind us of how many of those from Godly family's can be guiding lights in our communities ! I could offer many other examples – including some of our local church families. Maybe you can think of families who – although they are not even "official, titled" leaders in the church, their impact has been every bit as strong in your life as those who are recognized ministers in your church or community.

I spent countless alone in that room ! The luxury of that solitude gave me more opportunity to become a good student at school because I was able to concentrate fully on what I was reading without anyone disrupting me .

I had a dream in that room that is still vivid and meaningful to me today. I dreamt that my favorite Aunt, Aunt Martha DeVos, came to me in a crowd. She pulled me to where we faced each other in a squatting position . She said to me , "You used to be such a good Christian – get back on the mountaintop with God – pray again every night on your knees". Aunt Martha had already gone to Heaven; but, the dream was so powerful that it actually seemed that God sent her on a mission to me in a dream. Of course I don't know that; but, if that is possible, it seems that is exactly what happened. So, in that room, I resumed my nightly praying on my knees like daddy used to do with us every night when we were a lot younger. I got away from that habit over the years from time to time; but, that dream came back to me and for the last many years, when I am home, I once more pray on my knees every night.

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Child and young adulthood while still at home with my parents

The title of this book is about me going from being a “lost sheep” to becoming a shepherd.

Clearly I was put into a good Christian home . Both parents genuinely loved the Lord, showed forth His fruit, and tried their best to train me up into Him.

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Eventually I became rebellious too. I was more able to keep my rebellion a secret than my siblings. I did not fully rebel until I moved out of my parent’s home to live in Grand Rapids.

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I say “ not fully” rebel. There were signs of rebellion.

As I meditated on my life in preparation of writing this, I was ruthlessly honest with myself in answer to what led to my rebellion.

One of the first major flaws in my character that led to my downfall: I loved the boys. I have some memories of my preoccupation with boys starting in kindergarden. From kindergarden on there was always some boy I had a strong crush on. I mean obsessively strong. It would most always be some ninth grade boy. Sometimes more than one. If that person went to my church, as soon as we were seated I would look all around to see if that guy was in church and in a place where I could see him. Then throughout the service I looked at him over and over again. I would daydream about this person; I would imagine being with them as I went to sleep at night. I never shared this with anyone so I did not know (and still don’t) how this lands on the scale of normal to abnormal.

At ten years old I looked to be around fifteen. I had already hit puberty . My feet were size ten. I was not overweight; I was simply physically matured beyond my age. My current major crush was a boy of sixteen who went to Byron Center Public School . He would come on my side of the road each day I walked to Byron Center Christian School and we would stand and talk awhile. One day we took a walk together and he kissed me. Mind you, it was a closed mouth, dry kiss. But, it was my first kiss. I did not know that our Kent County Sheriff, Ralph Goeman, was keeping an eye on me and my frequent talks with Bud. He apparently decided I had hit an unacceptable amount of time with Bud and decided to come to our front door for the sole purpose of reporting my behavior to my parents. Thus ended this romance.

There was another boy who sparked my fancy. Also when I was ten. He was around thirteen. If you want to see his attendance for that year at Byron Center Christian, I still

have a record of it because I started the entries in my new diary with whether or not he was in school that day. I never told him what I felt; he never acknowledged me much. But at one after school family gathering at the school, I ended up outside against the school wall kissing him. Now that one generated new physical feelings within me.

Do you see something more dangerous that just a crush developing here?

When I was fourteen a young man of nineteen wanted to date me. My mom loved this guy and he was a very handsome, hard working young man with a spotless reputation. So my parents let me date him every other Friday night. I really liked him as a close friend and tried – for mom's sake – to like him for more than that; but, I could not make that happen. I wonder if they could see that I needed reining in and hoped this young man was a good candidate for that job.

When I was in high school I dated many guys. In the summers between my high school years I went out with a different guy every single night of each and every week. I had a calendar each year with all those names in it. By some miracle I stayed a virgin through all of high school; but, I loved to "make out".

The problem was that I still knew deep down that I was not intending to remain in the Dutch Christian Reformed culture. The young men I was seeing were all basically from Calvin or from South Christian High School. I enjoyed them and with some had a relationship that could have resulted in a perfectly acceptable marriage. In fact there was one young man that I loved so much that I broke up with him by explaining that I wanted to be with him but I could not because of who I thought I would be versus what would be expected of me in our mutual culture.

My desire to go out with so many boys and play huggy and kissy face caused me to lose focus on academics. From the time I was in ninth grade I had started to get A's and B's consistently on my report cards. In high school I was inducted into the National Honor Society. I know I could have gone from a BA to a Masters to a Doctorate without stopping if I had only been free of my obsession with guys. Guys were like a drug to me. I felt so pretty and special on those dates. Getting all dressed up, going to events, and going out to eat afterwards was thrilling enough. But, the time in the driveway once I was delivered home was the highlight of the night. I had a curfew and as soon as the time of the date was to end, daddy would switch the outdoor lights off and on to indicate that it was time to get into the house.

I saw no conflict between my dating behavior and my Christian walk. I was very ignorant of what it means to be "in Christ", to walk in the Spirit and avoid the works of the flesh.

I actually did like everyone I was with while I was with them and had no concept of how I may have hurt someone in giving them the impression they were very special to me and then giving the next guy that same impression the very next night. These guys were not

sophisticated “players” . Most all of them were very kind, simple , Christian guys . But I had no concept of their feelings; I was just having fun. Now I see this kind of behavior as very selfish and sinful; then I did not.

Right after High School I went to a mission program called “Summer Workshop in Missions” (S.W.I.M). I remember vividly our approach to the Sandia Mountains just before we entered Albuquerque, New Mexico. Suddenly I was attacked with the very strong and fearful thought, “You do not know what you are doing! You don’t know how to teach someone about the things in the Bible. You won’t know what to say. They wasted their money sending you here”. But the people sponsoring us had a plan and took us through it step by step. First we would do door by door invitations to the Vacation Bible School, then for two weeks we would help teach in the
VBS, then we would go door to door again to invite the parents to the program at the end of the VBS. I was assigned to the Navajo church with a Pastor Redhouse who was patient and kind in teaching us all we had to know and do. He also took us to minister to the TB sanatarium people. I loved all the people and the ministry work.

If only I did not love the boys so much.

It was not long before I met Abad Archuletta, a student at the High School where we were staying. We were staying in the dorms there. Every night after supper I would meet Abad in the yard .. We would talk for an hour or so and end up with some kissing ; the whole process would be repeated the following night. Our leaders found out about this and I was told, “We sent you here to evangelize, not to socialize.” I was told I would be sent home if I did not heed this warning.

After I came home from S.W.I.M a man named George Way called me and asked if I wanted to come for Lincoln Country Club. I would be working in the clubhouse serving the golfers beer, wine, and some food. It sounded exciting to me.

I did not realize that practically every guy who came there would try to fool around with me. There were few exceptions. I actually respected those guys who were faithful husbands and refrained from flirting with me! There were some that I actually made out with. The guys who delivered the beer got especially fresh in the freezer as I helped them unload the beer.

One guy really got attached to me. I went to the Christian Youth Camp at the end of the summer and he actually showed up on the camp grounds to see me at that camp! I told him I would be gone and where I was going but it never occurred to me he would come to see me. I was still eighteen and he must have been around thirty five.

I am leaving much information out in this section of explaining this flaw concerning guys. I want to convey the overall problem without getting into way too much detail. The reason I am dwelling on it will be clear when I deal with my eventual deliverance

experiences.

I entered Calvin College the Fall of 1964. During the first two years I still did a lot of dating but remained technically “pure”. I had gotten to the place that I so assumed someone would like me in a special way that I would be offered a ride back to Byron Center when I studied in the library (on the old Franklin Campus) until it closed . And it did happen. I had arrived in a car pool ;but, I did not have a car to get me back home.

Out of my home and on my own:

In the Fall of 1966 I took a job that radically changed the course of my life.

I started work at Kent County Juvenile home as a group worker.

I was nineteen. Previously they made twenty one their minimum age for the detention workers ;however, they took a chance on two nineteen year olds being mature enough to handle the job. One was me and the other was Mary Lindhout, now Mary Parker. Maybe she was mature enough for this; I wasn't. I was fine working with the girls; however, the boy crazy issue occurred again.

The first time I walked into the break room I encountered one of the shift supervisors, Chuck. The immediate nearly tangible electricity generated between us, two strangers, was nearly tangible. He was thirty four at that time; I was nineteen. We started almost immediately a nine month, intense relationship. The relationship was birthed from that electricity. There was no strong conversational connection and certainly nothing spiritual only the current running back and forth between us. I realized in a few months that this relationship was going nowhere lasting and had no idea how to break up with him. I was simply addicted to the physical attraction.

In sharing my very personal information my hope is that any young lady or woman reading this will begin to see how much precious time we waste when we follow the thrills and prevent ourselves from the kind of relationship God intends for us to enjoy.

How foreign is the Word of God concerning relationships when we are caught up in the shallow, fleeting connections!

The Bible says that our fellowship with each other is based on our fellowship with the Lord. **1Jo 1:3**

That which we have seen and heard declare we unto you, that ye also may have **fellowship** with us: and truly our **fellowship** *is* with the Father, and with his Son Jesus Christ.

When I contrast what I have with my husband, Robert, with all the many boys and men I have "had fun" with, the comparison is astounding. It is like comparing a swimming pool to the ocean! The depth, the content, the reach, the beauty of the ocean is endless. A relationship based only on some momentary thrill with no commitment or relationship grounded in the Lord is a totally dead end waste of time. Robert and I have not only the physical attraction and connection, we also do weekday morning devotions together with hearts as one in communication with our God. We listen to Bible lessons, we sing , and we pray. We discuss all aspects of life. We are committed through being annoyed with each other or being ecstatic in our time together.

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In 1966 one of the girls I cared about in the detention unit, Betsy, did not come home after her weekend family visit. She ran away. I asked some of her friends where she might be and they said , “1400 Madison, SE”. I was out with my friend , Hucko was her nickname, just riding around and I decided to visit that address. I went to the door and the guy who answered it looked at me and then turned around to tell his friends, “Here’s our ride to the roller rink”. Betsy was not there. I decided to provide the long ride to the south of town where the rink was.

The guy who answered the door was Louis Adams. We sat for a long time talking in the parking lot of the roller rink and Hucko was in the back seat talking to one of his friend. The other two guys eventually came out of the rink back to the car and we all went to a restaurant together on S. Division.

I took Louie home that night . I cannot tell you how our relationship evolved to what it became , I just remember many nights that I went to talk to him after I was done studying at Calvin or done with my work at Juvenile home. We would sit and talk for so long!

At first I thought we were simply developing a close friendship.

I actually thought he was younger than me. But he is a year older.

I began to notice the habitual nature of my going regularly to the side of his home with his Grandma at 600 Jefferson, SE. He would come to my car . It was hard to leave him. I was becoming very attached to him. But in the beginning I never thought I should stop seeing him because I was beginning to get too close. We were so different in our cultures, our upbringing, and in so many ways that I assumed I was not in danger of getting “hooked” into this relationship to the point I could not leave it. But I was getting hooked. You may even say “addicted”. No amount of reasoning could help you understand this because it did not make sense. Some say, “The heart wants what the heart wants” and that is the total explanation.

One thing that bound me to him was that he had been given to his Grandma, Lucille Taylor, to raise not long after his mom married Mr. Ford. Louie and his older brother Dan both were sent away and she proceeded to build a new and rather large family with Mr. Ford. I completely identified with being given away and wanted to be someone to him that he could trust not to “give him away” but to be family to him.

Running around with Louie gave me an education of living and playing in the ghetto. He took me to the clubs with him, the after hour places, and to his friend’s home. We repeatedly stayed overnight at that 1400 Madison SE address. Through him I learned the hard times he had with police encounters and job attempts. He had graduated from South High School , but at that point had never held a significant job. My heart was becoming very sympathic for those in his culture! During this time I developed a hatred for my own race. I got deliverance eventually from that; however, that spirit of hatred was with me

for some years. I saw the housing discrimination first hand . I experienced the wrongful treatment in public places simply for being with a black man. I loved the Motown music that was popular at that time. I first encountered this at the detention center and then was surrounded by it with Louie and his friends. The custom seemed to be to put a record on repeat mode when the song first came out so everyone would be able to memorize the words.

I was also getting good at speaking two languages: Ebonics and standard English. I would not consciously switch languages. I just naturally flowed with the language of whatever group I was with.

During this period with him the hatred of young black men, included his friends, bubbled up and boiled into a riot. Louie and his friends ended up in jail for participation in this riot. The riots occurred two years in a row. The "black rage" was in the air with fierce strength.

I experienced strong rage even though I am white. I wanted justice ! I was in full agreement with the civil rights movement.

At the same time I was learning about the black culture I was a student at Calvin. I was living in my native culture and in the black culture simultaneously. I could easily wear both hats. I was reminded then that I am white and I can escape the oppression experienced in the ghetto by black people any time I wanted to. My ability to be white culturally whenever I chose to be was a huge distinction between me and all of my new friends . This fact that caused me to realize I will never fully be able to empathize with actually being black with no relief from all the things that they must face.

My plan had always been to go to live in California after I graduated. So I gave my car to Louie said , "I love you, goodbye" and got on an airplane to San Franscisco.

I thought we were forever done. I did, however, give him my address and he wrote me letters.

I found the YWCA Residence Club on Powell. The room and board was 107.00 a month. Only women lived there. There's an excellent fresh start, right?

The setup was perfect . We all had a small room with a wardrobe, a sink , and a twin bed. My window overlooked Powell and the cable cars came by with all their bells frequently. On each floor there were bathroom with shower. Little sitting rooms record players were scattered throughout the building. On the first floor was a huge cafeteria where all the residents could eat breakfast and supper together. Had I not had that boy crazy issue I could have stayed there forever.

But, predictably I ventured out to explore Golden Gate Park, Fisherman's Wharf,

downtown, and even the Tenderloin district. That city was busy all night long.

The hippie movement was going full force. Thousands of young people had moved to San Francisco in order to "drop out" of the establishment and get high or drunk in the park and at the Wharf. "Make love, not war" was the theme. We were certainly faithful to conform to that theme!

Seven days a week I would go outside to play with the hippies. I was handed marijuana each day and I have no clue as to who was footing the bill for all this dope. I never paid for one joint. Musicians would be beating conga drums (sp) and others would be on corners playing saxophones or trumpets. Crowds of people would dance and some of these would manage to work themselves into a state of abandoning all restraint including seeming to be in a trance like condition, a place of having completely abandoning all their sense of normal decorum.

Probably because of the "proper" fashion of my upbringing (and the presense of multiple demons in me which I did not understand when I was living there), I was finally in a place of what I perceived to be complete liberty and happiness.

The one principle I could not ignore was the need to work hard and support myself. You would think my friends (quickly acquired, temporarily connected friends) would wonder why I could buy them food . I did not tell these drop outs I was actually working a forty hour week . To admit that would seem as if I were an establishment capitalist and I was not willing to "drop out" of the "system". Meanwhile, these young people were "panhandling" and sharing list of what places handed out free food, goods, and services. Many of those I met were like me:
They had degrees from excellent colleges.

Our conversations sometimes centered around how badly our country was being run, the Vietnam war was unfair and we need to end it, what we would all do it we were in charge of everything, and the disgusting nature of the conformity of the majority who were unwilling to be as wise as we were and discontinue participation in the deeply deceived , sheep like communities all over our county. And because iniquity shall abound, the love of many shall wax cold.

We would use words like "disestablishmentarianism" feeling proud of our depth of insight into the big corporations, churches, the "military industrial complex', and any other targets that seem so acceptable to the "main stream " of our society. We were the wise ones that saw clearly the conformity and corruption that abounded so we "dropped out" from agreement and participation.

We created our own counter culture.

Womens liberation was celebrated. At one point , because I agreed with the concept of

personal choice concerning careers and equal pay for equal work, I thought I was part of that group of woman. But, as the abortion and lesbian issues began to manifest as well as some hard core aggression against men , I realized , once again that I fit some with some people but not enough to make them “my tribe”.

Many of the predominant hippie thoughts and attitudes abide with me today. But I have redefined these values through the lense (sp) of the Word and the Spirit rather than through the secular perspective.

I dream about the day thousands of Christians could all spontaneously, frequently gather in some green space in a desire to praise and worship the Lord freely. In my “vision “ for this there would be pockets of people gathered in various spots throughout this space to dance to the Lord, to share their instruments in harmony, to sing in the Spirit, to pray, to eat together , and to treat each other as family simply based on their oneness in Christ.

Do you recognize in that “dream” the kingdom of the Lord vs. the kingdom of satan that prevailed in my San Francisco experiences?

I think of my longing for the things of the Spirit to be deeper in my life than ever before only to discover that thousands of people all over the world gathered in huge revival venues to search for and wait on the presence of the Lord together and desire all He had to give them to walk out a life of light and power.

The contrast of a similar phenomena in that young people all over the world “heard” the pied piper of the devil calling them to “make love, not war”, “drop out, get high”, and reject the values of what the church and their parents taught them seems to me that the enemy found a counterfeit for “revival”. We are all hungry for reality. The Lord has a path of power and light for us to walk on; the enemy counterfeits that path by telling us it lies in drugs, sex, liberty from restraint and rules, and looking within ourselves to be authentic to what we find within.

When I went to San Franscisco there was a popular song that enhanced the pied piper’s beckoning:

> If you're
> going to San
> Francisco
> Be sure to
> wear some
> flowers in
> your hair
> If you're
> going to San
> Francisco

You're gonna
meet some
gentle people
there

For those
who come to
San
Francisco
Summertime
will be a
love-in there
In the streets
of San
Francisco
Gentle people
with flowers
in their hair

All across the
nation
Such a
strange
vibration
People in
motion

There's a
whole
generation
With a new
explanation
People in
motion
People in
motion

Writer(s): Phillips John E A

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Golden Gate Park was indeed filled night and day with literally thousands of young people proclaiming peace and expressing love for all.

On Saturdays nights I literally spent one particular night with scores of kids “crashing” at some stranger’s apartment. I never knew who was the renter; I did not even know the others present. A new herd mentality: Trust and love all present; we are family.

Just like the song said: Gentleness and love. Who would not want that?

The repression I had felt for years of not being able to “be myself” in freely speaking my mind and expressing my emotions was finally lifted off from me. Everyone around me in the hippie settings was experiencing what seemed to be total liberation from those “strait, square” people who rejected freedom of expression and choice! “Do your own thing” was the norm. The “dominant society” was rejected; our new revolution was the best choice.

I was seduced and deceived by this collective mentality defining joy and liberty contrary to the truths of God’s Word.

I got in cars with guys whom I did not know. I thank the Lord I never met Charles Manson! Life on Spahn (sp) Ranch may have appealed to me at first sight.

One night I got in a white thunderbird with a guy named Chico. He took me to beach facing the ocean. He handed me a joint . When I smoked it something scary happened: My soul felt as if it we trying to leave my body and become one with the ocean! I willed myself to focus on the fight to keep me inside my body. I did prevail ;however, I often wonder if some young people literally “lose their minds” in the midst of a similar experience.

When I described my experience to some fellow hippie, I was advised that the joint was probably “laced with angel dust” and that I experienced a “bad trip”. That was a new concept: I could not trust drugs handed to me in a way I had always assumed over the counter drugs were consistent with their label.

When Chico and drove me back into the city, “Amazing Grace” came on the radio. At that time this song was actually number one on the “hit parade”! As I was listening I was totally repulsed by the “religious” nature of this song which I had previously cherished. Ironically the song is prophetic to each prodigal son or daughter who makes their way home to the Lord! “I once was blind, but now I see” is an apt description of my blindness at that moment compared to the light I walk in today. I now understand somewhat the meaning of a Romans 1: 18 For the wrath of God is

revealed from heaven against all ungodliness and unrighteousness of men, who hold the truth in unrighteousness; **19**Because that which may be known of God is manifest in them; for God hath shewed *it* unto them.

20For the invisible things of him from the creation of the world are clearly seen, being understood by the things that are made, *even* his eternal power and Godhead; so that they are without excuse:

21Because that, when they knew God, they glorified *him* not as God, neither were thankful; **but became vain in their imaginations, and their foolish heart was darkened**.

Living in sin can end in spiritual suicide! We become blind to the things of the Lord! The Lord in His Mercy and longsuffering can reach out and rescue us from our own folly ; but, to presume on being able to come back to Him when we keep on sinning and do not repent is way too risky. It is wiser to avoid entering the realm of the enemy and risky getting to the point of no return.

Our love for him is hardened through sinfulness. Matthew 24: 12, And because iniquity shall abound, the love of many shall wax cold.

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During that experience of literally hating to hear "Amazing Grace", my feelings horrified me. Part of me knew that Jesus was to be loved and obeyed; another part of me had given way to full apostasy.

Every night when I was in my room I would still pray before I slept and my prayer most always included the phrase, "Please, Lord, make me a better Christian". Whether sudden death at that stage of my life would hurl me into hell has no sure answer for me. I was living in total confusion and contradiction. In my effort to "find the real me", I got further and further from truth!

To illustrate to you another crack in my spiritual armour that actually gave me a reason to justify myself for pushing God away from me: Since around aged ten I had this recurring (sp) question: Why is God so unfair? I love my brother, Carl; but, from what I see in the Bible , if he does not repent and serve God, he will spend eternity in Hell. I did not understand how a loving God could do such a thing. That would be even worse than the public excommunication that our elders performed on Carl! I felt that was unloving; but, to send him to suffer forever? That was beyond understanding for me. I thought it would be fair for God to send him to hell for every year he lived here in rebellion against Him; however, to give and eternity of punishment for, e.g., fifty years of rebellion? No, that was not fair. My mind felt smarter than God in my reasoning. I will be honest with you in saying that I never got a satisfactory answer to this troubling issue. God simply

revealed to me that His mind is way higher than mine. I needed to give Him this issue. I would discover the answer when I met Him face to face. Meanwhile, God challenged me with a question of His own for me: Why should I go to hell for rejecting Him because of the Hell He will put the unrepentant rejectors of Him into? I love specific answers. I do not like waiting for years to understand something. But, this is one issue I have given to God to give me an understanding one day. Meanwhile, there is a trust I need to grow in so I don't think I always need to fully understand His decisions and ways.

I had a job but kept it a secret from my hippie friends. A lot of my friends had also just graduated from good colleges. But they had "dropped out" of mainstream America and chose to panhandle to get money (a fancy term for begging on the street. The usual approach was, "You got any spare change?") My dad had instilled a very strong work ethic in me and I simply could not panhandle. But I did not want my friends to think I had "sold out" to the "sytem" by getting a job. My job was at Apeco on Third Street. Apeco sold and serviced copy machines. I was the service secretary. I knew nothing which would help me go well on this job! I did not even know what it meant to file papers when I was handed pile of papers to put in the filing cabinet. I typed 18 words a minute. I sent each service man out to repair copy machines all over the map of the area and even small surrounding cities rather than give each man appointments in a certain section on the map. All the men surely put a huge, unnecessary amount of miles on their cars When they kept the appointments I assigned them! They may have enjoyed their travel time; but, I was not a great asset to the company in my inefficient planning!

I did not know shorthand. My boss, Ronald Yee, would call me into his office and dictate letters to me. I made my own abbreviations and tried to write as fast as I could.

People would call me and describe problems with their machine and I had no clue as to what they were talking about. "How do I get rid of the black ink on my copied paper?" I wanted to yell, "How in the world would I know?"

All this ignorance did not get me close to being fired. I think Ronald had some sort of fatherly concern for my well being. But what did inspire him to give me a week of severance pay and tell me to go back home to Michigan? He observed me and the other secretary coming back after the lunch break being obviously high off a drug. We had smoked marijuana on our break.

No way would I have obeyed someone telling me to "go back home". I would have just gotten another job.

Marriage to Louie

But, about the same time Ronald relieved me of my job, Louie called and said he was in Albuquerque and his next flight was taking him to San Francisco so would I please pick him up at the airport. I did. I told him to "Go home". But then I had sympathy for all the trouble he took to get there and said I would show him around San Francisco for a few days before he should go home.

Just now I realized, over fifty years after the fact, that he did not have a return airline ticket. Perhaps he figured he would live there too?

At the end of my showing him around and he was to go back, he persisted in asking me to return with him. I did. We took a greyhound home. We went to live with his sister , Beulah, at 1139 Layfayette, S.E. I began working as a third grade teacher at Sheldon Grade School . The second semester of my teaching year school he said to me , "I will prove I love you by marrying you." On February 22, 1969 we were married. We moved into our own apartment.

Our marriage was very stormy. He still hung out all hours of the

night with his friends. I remember sitting in the bathroom that faced the road looking out, crying, waiting hour after hour for him to come home. Sometimes he did not come home.

I must tell you of a time when the Lord especially made Himself known to me after an extremely volatile time with Louie that inspired me to run out of our house at 845 Bates SE with nothing (nothing!) on me except a winter coat. Barefoot in several inches of snow I ran to the corner of Bates and Eastern SE. If you know that neighborhood you know how dangerous it was for me to be out after midnight alone flagging down cars so I could get out of that area immediately. I had no idea whether I was going into an even worse scenario with whoever offered me a ride. I just was desperate to leave.

A white couple stopped to pick me up. White people being in our neighborhood at that time of night was rather rare. The area was somewhat dangerous. But even more surprising and obviously supernatural is that I found out within minutes that this couple was related to Galen Meyer. He was the chaplain for our S.W.I. M. team in the summer of 1964. They took me directly to his home on Madison SE, just north of Alger. He and his wife, "Sam" . took me in immediately, clothed me, and put me to bed. I had no doubt whatsoever that the Lord was watching over me that night!

The next day Gaylen, Sam , and I listened together to a new, popular album, "Jesus Christ , Superstar". There was a portion of one song that impacted me deeply , The last a chorus in the title song: "Jesus Christ Superstar, Do you think you're what they say you are?" Those words deeply touched me by provoking me to ask questions about the Lord.

Because he is now walking closely with the Lord I am choosing not to go into many details of all the issues I faced with him. I will simply say that there came the day about seven years after I married him that I picked up our adorable little three year old son and drove across the country to San Diego , California .

The night before I left, we had had a particularly harrowing time.The next day I went to work, but I felt such heaviness about ever returning to my apartment with them.So without even going back home to pick up any clothing or valuables.I went to the bank and withdrew $300

and then I went to the church daycare center where EG was and picked him up.And I just went straight to California.

I really need to add that I was not all I should have been to Louie. I did some things that hurt him deeply too. Since then we have totally forgiven on another. But we both had cause to be disappointed in one another during our marriage.

Back to California

On the way to California I stopped in Chicago to see Mary. I spent the night with her in their wonderful Penthouse on the "Gold Coast". The next day she gave me some outfits and food on my way back on the road. Other than what was on my back, that is all I had. E.G. had what he was wearing. Later my sister Shelly sent me some things from my former home.

This was 1975. I was able to buy a hotel for a night for under twenty dollars. I was well aquainted with Goodwill and the Salvation Army so I knew I could get more clothing there. Three hundred dollars stretched very far back in that year!

I applied for unemployment compensation as soon as I got to California. Even though I had abruptly quit, my supervisors knew my situation and did not treat me as if I just whimsically deserted my job. I got the compensation.

During my drive to San Diego I was overwhelmed with rage and hatred that produced murderous fantasies. I had never felt anything like that before! This went on for two weeks . I cried out to the Lord to save me from these evil thoughts! The Lord made it plain to me that I must forgive Louie and pray faithfully for him. I obeyed. In another two weeks I was filled with love and compassion for him. The love was not the married kind. To be honest it was closer to motherly love towards a foster son who was beloved but impossible to live with. I realized that I always loved him ; but, it was strongly mixed with a “I will help you” heart . God intended for two people to maturely stand side by side in a marriage, not for the wife to forever have a “my love can heal you” motive.

I sometimes attribute that attitude to a movie we watched yearly when I was a girl at home. The movie about Father Flanagan’s Boys Town had as its theme “There is no such thing as a bad boy”. The pitch was given that any boy with enough love surrounding him would come out of rebellion and naughtiness. I fell for that pitch. It is NOT true. People can sometimes just be naughty and loving them unconditionally can simply enable them to keep being bad. They can assume that you will put up with anything from them because you always do.

Soon I will testify about the spiritual revolution I experienced around 1971. I left Louie in May of 1975. By then I was Spirit filled and speaking in tongues for about four years. I loved my church, Bethel Pentecostal, and my paster, Elder Abney (later he became Bishop Abney). Thursday nights I would go to the meetings of Cal and Loie Bergsma who actually became spiritual parents to me. I will write more about them later.

Cal had met Louie and thoroughly knew our situation. On a couple of occasions things got so heated at home that I ran to Cal and Loie’s home for comfort and shelter. They took me in and let me stay with them until I returned back home. I trusted Cal’s judgement so I wrote Louie after I left him to say that if he counseled with Cal and Cal informed me that it was a good Idea for me to come back home after I was gone, then I would do so. Louie did go to see him once after I left.

At first upon arrival in San Diego I was totally at peace to just be with my son and the Lord.

I went to my uncle’s home and lived with my step cousin for awhile. She and her boyfriend were determined that I should find a boyfriend. They brought a guy to meet me

and even if I were on an island for months with him alone I would not be interested in him. Then they apparently figured out by E.G.'s complexion they needed to bring someone else over and they brought in a fellow Navy guy named Robert. So, in spite of my "never again" attitude towards marriage at that moment, I went out with him. The love of guys button got pushed; the door opened again. I won't list all of those I related to; I will only say that the same syndrome of my young years started all over again.

I should add a young man with whom I spent some time because of something that happened with he , a woman friend of his, and EG and I went to Tijuana , Mexico to a restaurant together . While we were sitting there a young man around thirty or so came into the door and walked straight to me. He handed me a black velvet scroll with a painting on it. The painting depicted a sheep underneath a tree. The tree had a wildcat in it who was about to pounce on the sheep. In the distance was a flock with a shepherd. That sheep who was in danger had wandered from the shepherd and the safety of being in the flock with that shepherd. The message to me was clear! Return to the Shepherd and His flock – you are in danger. I asked the young man what was his name. He said "Jesus" (pronounced as the Mexicans pronounce that name) and walked back to the door and left. He did not try to get friendly with or carry on a conversation with me. He had obviously come in with one assignment: Give Rosemary this picture. Because of the many times the Lord showed Himself to me in obvious ways I nearly named this book "The Fingerprints of God on my Life".

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One day I went to the phone book to see if I could find a church to attend. I saw Home Ministry Fellowship listed. I went to the house church of Charles and Bobbie Stilwell, founders of that ministry. They invited E.G. and me to live at their home. I had supernatural favor with them right away. I moved in.

I told Charles of my ongoing thoughts about loving to have a house for homeless people. He told me about a lady, Sharon Langely, who owned and operated the Emmanuel House which was a house for homeless men. I went to visit them in the Hillcrest district of San Diego. Could you predict that there would be a man there named Roscoe who was in charge of hands on caretaking of that house and who led the praise an worship every night and that this man would lay an immediate claim on me?

Sister Sharon liked me and invited me to live in the house and help out. E.G. and I were given a twin bed in the pantry, a room about 5' by 8'. I had been getting unemployment compensation ; but, because I would be helping out in this house, I told them to stop sending me the checks. I helped by teaching Bible studies in the afternoon to the men.

God was so faithful to provide for EG and me. At the Immanuel House.Having gotten rid

of the employment compensation.Uh.Sister Sharon started to give me $3 a week for expenses well between Indian and obviously that's not going to cover everything that we we would need.A very special miracle occurred during that time. I realized it wouldn't be long and I'd have to buy a box of tampons, tampons, costs, a lot of money.And I wondered how every month I was going to have money to buy them.Well, the men at the Immanuel House went to dumpsters by the supermarkets in order to find food.For the Immanuel House one day, one of the men came up to me, really looking awfully sheepish about this, but he said I found something you might need, and he handed me a completely unopened box of 40 tampons that he had found in the dumpster that day.I saw clearly saw the hand of God saying I care for all of your needs.

Around mid summer I began to wonder if I was supposed to stay away from Louie for good. I reminded the Lord what I said about coming home if Cal said it was healthy for me to do that. Very quickly after my conversation with the Lord, my good friend, Cathy Barrow called me to say that Cal had died! I took that as a very definite, loud, clear response from the Lord concerning my conversation with him. Cal could no longer tell me, “Come home”. I felt confirmed in staying away.

The reason I was attracted to Roscoe and , therefore, strongly entertained the idea of and then accepted becoming his girlfriend was that he was working fulltime for the Lord . His focus seemed to be primarily on this work. As he got more attached to me, the less he wanted to discuss the Lord and he just wanted to concentrate on me. I began losing interest in him the more I saw his focus was shifting.

He became quite controlling. He did not attend the afternoon Bible studies I taught the men; but, he showed up every day five minutes before my assigned finish time. He was not about to allow me to have one minute to relate to those other guys outside of me formally standing up teaching!

Why I “obeyed” him when he was not even my husband is puzzling to me. I could have told him I would come and find him when I was ready rather than have him control me!

Sister Sharon approached me one day and asked if I was interested in becoming the manager of a house for homeless women that she was about to open up. Of course I was! I told Roscoe what I was about to do and he was totally against my accepting her offer. Why again did I defer to him? This job would have settled me into San Diego for the first time in a way I could take care of E.G. and myself without depending on anyone else to take me in! It was a job I was not only fully qualified for but on the top of the list at that time of what I would have considered a “dream job”! Something within me kept allowing my relationship with a man be a stumbling block to being close to the Lord and His path for me!

My relationship with Roscoe lasted about five months.

I was beginning to feel very limited and confined by being with Roscoe. I remember one day picking up a magazine and staring at a picture that inspired me to want to sit down and write some poetry. I realized that there was no significant stretch of time for me to be able to do such a thing. Roscoe would surely need or want me for something without any understanding of my need for solitude to be creative. No way could I live a life with him that centered always around his activity choices with no regard to what I may want to do. Another important fact is that I was E.G's mom. He was just three years old. He needed me more than anyone else did! I had to carefully measure my time between the two of them so as not to annoy Roscoe. Why could I not simply be a single mom and raise E.G. without any need to be around a man?

I ran away from Roscoe one night after we had attended an evangelistic crusade downtown. I went up for prayer and to find someone to confide in about my desire to escape my present situation. The altar worker I spoke with set up overnight housing for me at a pastor's daughter's home. She had set up a bed in their garage just in case someone in need like me would show up with a housing need. They did let me and E.G. inside their home for breakfast; however, they related to me as most would to a homeless person. Although I fully understood they did not know me and they had to be cautious for the sake of their family whom to let inside their home, I felt ashamed to be a person placed in the garage to sleep because they did not know if I was good or evil. And, I was, in fact, a homeless person at the moment.

I was introduced by her to a lady named Barbara who was a member in her dad's church. Barbara agreed to let E.G. and me live with her. She had two girls : One was twelve the other was nine. She had a sofa bed in her living room that E.G . and I slept on. I gave her forty dollars a week for room and board.

I was grateful to have a nice place to stay in a good area . In most every way Barbara and I got along just fine. We had long talks confiding in one another about things we had experienced. We did seem to have a loving , mutual respect.

Her girls started to make complaint lists against me. Some points on this list: I did not wipe up the droplets from the floor after showering ; I ate too much cereal. Then Barbara criticized me for going out too much. We should work at being family, she said. I did not sign up to be a part of this family in the literal sense! After leaving Roscoe I craved the liberty to come and go when and where I wanted . In this case I chose to attend nightly some meetings at a place called "The Upper Room" in downtown San Diego. I did not submit to Barbara's request for me to stay at home !

One wonderful thing about my stay with Barbara: I managed to stay "man free". That

was liberating. Finally I could just concentrate on E.G. and myself.

One incident that was particularly sad for E.G.and me: I bought EG some new tennis shoes. The girls took them and threw them in the dumpster. They admitted they were jealous of him. The atmosphere for E.G. in this living arrangement was polluted! He was too little to express for himself what it felt like to have them destroy his new shoes. My job was to protect him from such an environment!

The girls had finished their list of complaints about me so Barbara called a meeting so I could be confronted with this list. Their complaints were not even mentioned in this meeting! Both girls started immediately yelling at their mom when we started our discussion. They felt she was keeping them from being with their dad. Barbara was divorced and had full time custody , but, there was a provision for the dad to be with the girls that Barbara , in their opinion, was blocking. The girls were crying and sharing their feelings! I just looked on in silence and in amazement That was my first experience in discovering that what people think is the problem (my faults in this case) is a big mask to cover up the real problem.

This was a valuable lesson that has served me especially in my years of pastoring. There are those that complain about church issues, leave the church , and then divorce each other. Over and over I have seen that what people complain about is many times not actually the source of the pain they are in and are afraid to talk about! This realization has helped me to often overlook any normal personal pain that could arise when someone expresses dissatisfaction with the church or us .

I started attending an apostolic church led by Bishop Cannon on Imperial St. in San Diego. I took off my makeup and jewelry per his request. The reason I stuck with them in spite of the restraints in freedom of expression is because the love and hospitality was wonderful. Love truly can cover a multitude of sins, in this case, a multitude of senseless, religious rules. I was making friends in the congregation and spent some time out of church with them both in their homes and on an overnight church trip to San Francisco.

Jean Oates was a member of this church. Although I had expressed no need for a place to stay, she said I could live with her. Jean nor I had no idea that Barbara would soon inform me that the Lord told her to tell me to move out. I knew the Lord did not tell Barbara this because I had just given her eighty dollars for room and board for the next two weeks. She told me to leave immediately. . If the Lord had told her to say that He would also have told her to give me my money back !

With gratitude I remembered Jean's offer. Obviously the timing of her offer was supernatural because only God knew that I would soon need another place. Jean was a loving, quiet ,sweet woman. She and I got along perfectly . I could have stayed with her

indefinitely.

Can you believe that rather than being thoughtful and faithful in and around Jean's righteous home , I got into a relationship with the neighbor guy, David? Jean was usually not home in the day time. I would wake up to The thought of killing the many mice I saw in Jeans's house was repulsive to me so I asked David if he would come over and help me kill them. There were many mice so he came over quite a lot to set traps and empty them. So we got to know each other . He was not a Christian and , therefore, not an appropriate close friend for me. I became close to him for about a month .

I told you my problem with liking men too much was a huge character flaw that kept me from a lot of blessings ! This issue started early on and by now I was twenty eight and still could not seem to establish proper boundaries and exercise good discernment concerning men!

God rescued me from continued involvement with David when I got a telegram from my sister that Dad had died. E.G. was about to have his fourth birthday. A package from Dad had just arrived from him into our mailbox. It was a shiny red metal tractor. Dad died within a day or so after our getting that gift in the mail.

Dad loved E.G. and E.G. adored his Grandpa. All the discussions dad and I had when I decided to marry Louie about "race mixing" not being God's way stopped when E.G. was born. From that day on Dad's love for E.G. was so intense that I believe dad would have defended E. G. from anyone who dared to suggest that white folks should not be close friends with black folks! Mom loved him too; but, E.G. was his Grandpa's boy in a special way.

I have a deep continuing regret that I left without saying "Good bye" nine months earlier to anyone thus not giving mom and dad the opportunity to hug me and him before we went on our trip. I was so totally done with all of my marital issues that I was dimwitted about any other necessary .

Because of my own past behavior, I give many young adults immediate forgiveness for any quick changes they decide to make that might result in hurting others in their lives. I totally understand the state of mind that gets so self absorbed with depression and confusion that the empathy for others that should be an influence in making radical moves is simply lacking. Many times humans do the only thing they can think of to escape misery and have no clue how their decisions may hurt others!

Now Grandpa Herms was dead and I chose to go home to take care of my mom.

So I left all my belongings at Jean's home and flew back to Grand Rapids. I had just enough cash for a one way ticket. This was the third time in about a year's time that I left

my earthly goods to make a quick getaway.

My mom told me she had to get a new address book during that season of my life because she filled up a page with my addresses and had nowhere left when I came up with a new one.

I explained very carefully to E.G. that Grandpa had gone to live with Jesus. He, I said, would see the earth body that Grandpa lived in, but Grandpa was no longer living in that body. I told him that he would see Grandpa again one day when he, E.G., went to live with Jesus too.

It is amazing how earnestly I believed what I told E.G. and how rebellious I could be concerning how I knew God wanted me to live!

When we got to the viewing night before the funeral, my four year old son walked up to his Grandma Herms and carefully explained to her everything I told him about Grandpa's current state to make sure she would know too. Watching and listening to him do that moved my heart with much admiration that he took all I told him by faith and proceeded to comfort his grandma with this knowledge.

E. G. had a heart to comfort others. For example, once , just before we left for California, he saw me crying . He figured out a way to comfort me: He went and got his teddy bear that he slept with and brought it

to me to hug. He got comfort from Teddy and surely , he thought, mom would too.He was an extraordinarily sweet, loving little son!

E.G. and I went to live with Mary's daughter, my sister , Shelly. Shelly had two children, Gypsy (E.G.'s age) and Danny who was a bit younger. These kids enjoyed each other so much! Again I am thinking that we could keep this arrangement forever! I had already decided I never wanted to marry again so what better situation than for Shelly and I to establish a loving, stable home for our kids? She expressed that same desire so we moved from her apartment to 1141 Hermitage, S.E. to begin a new life blending our families together.

I had introduced Shelly to Bethel Pentecostal Church and she was still attending there. I was happy to return to Bethel.

My life seemed finally back on a good path! I would, I believed, serve the Lord without disruption .

Ways in which my jobs prepared me to become a pastor

Long before I left to live in San Diego I had gotten a job as a social worker for Kent County Department of Social services. I worked there from 1969 to 1975.

It would be easy to write a book on all that I did and learned on this job! I loved it. Every gift God had given me was called into play and I even stretched into manifesting some abilities I did not even know I possessed until new challenges were given to me.

Remember I told you about my secretarial job in San Francisco, i.e., I had no idea what I was doing. The same was true when I walked into the door the first time to work at the Kent County Department of Social Services then located on Butterworth , S.W. in Grand Rapids. I actually don't remember taking the test and applying for the job. I had no idea

what “Social Services” did. They handed me a whole lot of manila files telling me these were my ADC (Aid to Dependent Children) cases. I had never heard of ADC. I knew of no one in my upbringing who was on welfare. In the beginning as a social worker I was to do both the welfare grant creation and the social work. They had some complicated formula about how to calculate their grant if they also had income from work. I think I overpaid clients for the first couple of years until I better understood their formula. No one formally trained me. My five fellow workers helped me learn the job. We were in a small room with six big desks, three on one wall, three on the other , both sides sitting very close to one another. In time these folks became like a family to me.

I was supposed to get a three month and a six month evaluation during the beginning of my job there. I got one evaluation after nine months. That is when my math error became apparent to me.

Going back to when I became a third grade teacher at Sheldon School I just now realized that same pattern of knowing nothing when I start out happened there too. I was a class full of children, an aide to help me (who only did what I told her to do, she could not guide me). There were some reading books in the room, papers, pencils, and a black board. We were in a poor district and supplies we not ample.

I decided “reading , writing, and arithmetic” was my best avenue of approach.

Then I found out I was dealing with everything from pre primer, to primer, to late second and early third grade learners . One book certainly did not fit all. So I put the books aside and created what was a phonics program. We sounded out vowels and consonents . We advanced to consonant blends. Then we attacked script by sounding out words. Eventually we added meaning and expression.

Math was easy to figure out how to teach. Writing not so easy for these kids. But,the point is , I concentrated on the necessary basics. We had to hand in a weekly plan to the principal. I don’t think she was on to the fact I was making up things as I went along.

My plan actually worked in advancing each ones knowledge.

I can see by God placing me in these positions for which I was ignorant how I learned that I can learn and be creative as I move along. I don’t have to know everything about a job before attempting to do it.

I remember when we started River of Life wondering if there were books about “How to start a church”. I could not find anything. The Lord taught us as we moved along in Him.

When we were told in prophesy that we were called to go to the nations and minister, I wondered if there were books on how to do that. I looked . I found none. We had to just

do it. We learned as we moved along.

I made hundreds of home calls to my welfare clients which gave me an entirely new education about poverty as well as a deep appreciation for most all of my clients whose character I admired because of their strength in the midst of their struggles.

When I returned from San Diego, I got my job back. In the last seven years at that job, 1976 to 1984, I worked as an employment services worker which gave me an opportunity to draw up employment plans with hundreds of clients. A worker from the Employment office and I would evaluate each client in the area of abilities (General aptitude test battery), interest, and personality. Each day , Monday through Friday, there were new groups in the morning and in the afternoon. We dealt with around forty people a day. I did a motivational speech concerning getting back to work for each group. After we would make and review the test results, we sat down individually with each client to draw up a plan for their employment. We would discuss what the barriers were to their going to work and then make plans to overcome those barriers. If it was a lack of work experience, I would solicit work sites where the person could work for around three months (with all their welfare benefits continuing) so they could get a good recommendation for another job. If the barrier was education , we could send them to school or to a training program. Whatever barrier they faced, we tried to find a solution. . I loved that job and would have retired there if the Lord would not have called me to become a pastor. I must add that the work I did for fourteen years as a social worker was extremely valuable as part of my training to become a pastor.

Some at my church now seem to believe that I was born with an ability to talk freely to strangers of every cultural background and ethnicity. The truth is that I had to make probably what adds up to thousands of home calls over the course of fourteen years to ask strangers a whole range of very personal questions . This activity no doubt trained me to be open and free with everyone I meet.

Being a social worker in the job assigned to me had a lot of the same challenges as I now have as a pastor. I must evaluate where a person is at and help them to develop a strategy to grow up into Christ. Sometimes obvious barriers to their growth become obvious. People need a plan to eliminate the barriers. We must discern where they would best fit in our local church working alongside us. We can offer teaching and experience to help them excel at whatever “placement” the Lord has in store for them. The wonderful difference between this job description and my job at Social Services is that the Bible is our textbook and God’s Spirit is our guide.

You have just read a sketchy account of my many poor choices even after being filled with the Holy Spirit! **I was just as disgusted with myself as you probably are in reading about all my poor choices. I have not even included all of those choices in this narrative. I am sure I gave you enough to get the general idea of my need for more wisdom fo.**

My behavior brings up many questions about how far the Lord will go to remain at the side of someone who keeps returning to sinful behavior! We also need to be careful before we assume someone is definitely a hypocrite or a hopelessly backslidden because we do not know what is going on inside of them!

I brought you to 1976 and my return to Grand Rapids. But now I am going back to 1970. I now want to tell you about the story of my spiritual walk .

Bishop Abney of Bethel Pentecostal Church used to sing the song , "Jesus is the Best Thing" by James Cleveland. One part says , ' If anyone should ever write, my life storyFor whatever reason there might be

You'd {Jesus} be there, between each line of pain and glory

Jesus is the best thing that ever happened to me."

This is my testimony too. Jesus was always with me not matter how far I strayed!

I was truly a lost sheep!

I truly do not remember a time in my life when I did not believe in the Lord Jesus Christ. I do not remember a moment of receiving Him as my Savior because I don't remember a moment when I did not see Him as my Savior.

I was raised in a truly Christian home. We had devotions with every meal we ate together. Dad would begin with a prayer and after we ate we read the Bible and prayed again.

We went to church during week night activities, Saturday catechism classes, and two services on Sunday.

I loved going to church as a child. I sincerely believed all the Bible stories I was taught. I loved the songs. I enjoyed any social activities we had. Back then if someone had a wedding the whole church came to it with snacks following in the church basement. Often there would be somewhat of a "variety program" at the reception too. We were truly a church family who cared about each other.

Mom and Dad sent all three of us to Christian Schools. From Kindergarden through my senior year at Calvin College there were either devotional times or chapel services to attend daily as well as Bible study courses. We were well grounded in the Word.

As long as we lived at home we were expected to go to church. When I moved out at aged 18 in 1966 in my Junior year of Calvin I promptly dropped out of church. I did not stop believing. I had a job at juvenile court and heavy class loads. I was also socializing and partying way too much. I did not make church a priority.

In 1970 I made a decision to stop being rebellious and started to go back to church, the mainline denominational church of my childhood. During all my times of rebellion I was still a believer. I wanted to return fully to the Lord and to a church home.

I went to Grace Christian Reformed Church on the corner of Buckley and Sheldon. . One outstanding memory of being there was a time I was in a skit. My lines were the verses from Isaiah :

Isa 60:1 Arise, shine; for thy light is come, and the glory of the LORD is risen upon thee. **2** For, behold, the darkness shall cover the earth, and gross darkness the people: but the LORD shall arise upon thee, and his glory shall be seen upon thee.

As I said them with all the drama and expression I could muster, I realized I had no idea what Isaiah was talking about. But my spirit inside was deeply moved by these words.

This was the first time that happened to me. Since then I heard sermons and read passages that touched me without my mind understanding why. This phenomena has caused my search to spiritual truths in the Lord to be exciting. When He points at a truth and I know that there is something deeper there, that is my cue from Him to search out the meaning. Now I totally understand Isaiah 60: 1,2. I could preach for hours that passage as my overall truth.

The Lord was stirring me up to give me a hunger to know and understand Him more.

I have heard others say sometimes that they did not enjoy a sermon because they could not understand what the preacher was talking about. When I , on the other hand, hear a sermon that is way over my head, I often get a sense of whether or not what is being said is something I need to understand. Then I add those thoughts to my searching for truth. A great , happy satisfaction occurs in me when I finally "get it". Some concepts have taken years to understand!

When I became part of Grace Christian Reformed Church in 1970, I began to wonder why in the book of Acts the Christians were so much further along than we were. There were signs and wonders, people shared all their belongings, they were willing to be persecuted for the Lord's sake, and they had way more passion for God than I had ever experienced. At that point I had not seen any one else either who lived up to those Acts Christians. I asked many others what they thought about this question, i.e., why would Christians go backward over the centuries rather than forward in our walk with God? Finally Carla Collins , a member of Grace, told me about charismatic meetings in town at St. Mary's Church. I was surprised that the Lord would move so strongly among the Catholics! I supposed that most of us Christian Reformed protestants agreed a Catholic could not be a saved person. When I went to their meeting I knew I had found what I was looking for. Unlike the incident I experienced when I was young when I expected some sort of expression on someone's face when they are singing about the good things of the Lord, these people were radiant with their expressions of joy and love! There was a moment when one of the nuns (in full old school nun clothing) sang beautifully in tongues and another nun sang the interpretation. This was my first time ever hearing anything like that! The people after the meeting were freely hugging each other and expressing their joy in the Lord.

I had lunch one day with my Grace CRC pastor and tried to explain to him what I had

seen at the charismatic meeting. I told him how all this was helping me love Jesus more. His response? “Are you bragging?” A pastor responding to my sincere testimony with a totally inappropriate response! Should my increasing love for the Lord not cause my pastor to be happy?

In spite of – or perhaps because of – my newly stirred up interest in the things of the Lord, I began to experience the depression again that had plagued me in my senior year in high school and during my junior and senior year at Calvin. Now that I understand spiritual warfare more than I did back then I understand satan’s tactics in using that weapon of depression against me to discourage my new spiritual awakening.

Seek help with the Calvin Campus Psychologist

When I was at Calvin I went to the school psychologist, Dr. Byjkerk (sp?) to help me deal with both severe depression and a snake phobia. If I even saw a garden hose I would see a snake and be repulsed to an abnormal degree. I would see snakes in my mind before I went to sleep . I could not look at a picture of a snake or go into that part of the zoo where they kept them. I needed to be rid of that!

I saw him from 1966 through 1968 when I graduated. During the summer of 1967 he actually saw me daily , Monday through Friday .

One day he asked me to draw a picture of the snake I saw. It was a python.

He also knew I was dabbling in the occult, especially in the use of the Ouija Board. He suggested I take it with me to one of his sessions with me. I declined.

He decided to hypnotize me thinking that might unveil some hidden secret from my past. That did not happen. But I did “see” a place full of huge eggs. One hatched and produced the Greek mythological horse with wings , Pegasus. The horse quickly evolved

into its full stature and flew away.

Wikipedia says, In Archaic Greek mythology, Pegasus is the offspring of the Gorgon Medusa,[1] when she was depicted as a mare. In later myths, Pegasus was foaled by Medusa as she was dying, while being decapitated by the hero Perseus.

Today is the first time I have read that aspect of Pegasus. When I was in high school in Latin class there was a picture of Medusa, whos had snakes on her head where hair should be. I was so negatively moved in seeing that picture that I took my ball point pen immediately and strongly pressed hard to cover with scribbling that entire image. I could not bear to look at it! I never knew until now that she was supposed to be Pegasus ' mother. I find it strange that one reason to talk to the doctor was the snake phobia and then under hypnosis I have a "vision" of Pegasus who, according to some accounts is the son of Medusa, the lady with snakes for hair. I believe that the ancient Greek gods we demonic spirits . What was the nature , therefore, of those spirits attacking me?

I realize now that hypnotism is part of the occult arts and that this inner "vision " of Pegasus has meaning concerning the enemy's plan for my life.

Because I am dealing with the snake subject right now, I will tell you that it was not until years later that I got more insight into the python spirit. In Acts **16:16** And it came to pass, as we went to prayer, a certain damsel possessed with a pirit of **divination** met us, which brought her masters much gain by soothsaying:

The word "divination" is , according to Strong's: **Pýthōn.** poo'-thone; from Πυθώ Pythṓ (the name of the region where Delphi, the seat of the famous oracle, was located); a Python, i.e. (by analogy, with the supposed diviner there) inspiration (soothsaying):—divination.

I had no idea about this when I drew the python for the psychologist. I drew the demon working in me to draw me into the occult arts! My Mary mom told me that as she was contemplating how to abort me, she went to a fortune teller to find out what to do. That fortune teller told her that every spirit needs a channel to pass through in order to come into the world. She said that Mary should be a channel for me to enter in. I believe the very act of going to a fortune teller while I was in the womb was enough for that spirit of divination to enter into me.

I never got rid of the depression by seeing the psychologist; however, the sessions with him opened me up even more into occult involvement .

Returning to 1970: Because of the depression attacks reoccurring, I was asking the Lord for a special , Christian woman friend to come into my life so that I could communicate with someone who walked in the Spirit. I thought that might help me.

I was at Rogers Plaza in Wyoming, Michigan at my lunch break one day . While there I bumped into my childhood piano teacher , Ruth Lanninga Kamps. She said to me, “You are the one I am to invite to the luncheon”. God had told her to go into Rogers Plaza to find the one he would show to her to take to a Christian luncheon across the street at the Sweden House restaurant.

I called my Social Services to ask for a couple hours of vacation leave so I could go there.

At the restaurant I sat next to Lois Bergsma whom I met for the first time that day. As I was talking to her I shared that my husband was not walking with the Lord. I also told her I hated white people. She was white. She was unmoved by that statement. Perhaps because she was white and we had been chatting so amicably she did not really believe me. The fact was I had no hatred for her in particular.

Soon after I met Loie, I took the day off work because I was thinking strongly of killing myself. The depression was strong and everything looked so hopeless in my life. The phone rang. It was Loie .She had called Ruth Kamps to find out my maiden name and

then looked up “Herms” in the phone book to get my mom’s number. She then called my mom to find out my phone number. Lois said that the Lord had put Louie strongly on her heart so that she would pray for his walk with the Lord. She said the Lord would not waste her time if He was not intending to deal with Louie.

Sometimes I have gotten really close to someone and I could not tell you how that closeness evolved. That was the case with Loie. Her husband, Cal, and Loie and I became very close.

Her husband was the pastor of Ivanrest Christian Reformed Church. He was “Pastor Bergsma”, very dignified man who conformed to what a Christian Reformed Pastor was expected to be.

Loie became interested in being baptized in the Spirit with the evidence of speaking in tongues right after she read David
Wilkerson’s book, The Cross and the Switchblade. She told the Lord that she wanted what David had no matter what it took for that to happen. Then she quickly said of her 18 month old daughter, Maria, lying in a crib next to their bed “But don’t take her”. It is a mystery as to why she would say that! An even greater mystery is the fact that within a very short time Maria was dead. When maria needed an operation Loie informed the surgeon that perhaps he needed to first find a way to test Maria’s reaction to the anesthesia because she was allergic to so many things. He disregarded this piece of information and put the full anesthesia dose on her. Maria died instantly.

Loie did receive the baptism in the Spirit and subsequently became a powerful teacher of God’s Word as well as a woman of exceptional faith and boldness.

Her husband’s first response to her experience was disgust.

The Christian Reformed Church at the time did not teach that we could have the experience described in Acts 2 nor all the other signs and wonders done by the disciples written about in Acts. Now many Christian Reformed people have received this experience; however, it is still rare to find a Christian Reformed Church in which the gifts of the Spirit are openly flowing in a public service. Often it is quietly accepted by some but not promoted openly on the pulpit.

For a while Loie’s excursion into this unfamiliar encounter with the Holy Spirit was a source of disagreement and discomfort between them. Being the honest man of God that he was, he began to see that this experience was Biblical and he wanted it too. As he became more enlightened through prayer and verses in the Bible about the baptism in the Holy Spirit, He began to teach about the Holy Spirit in his pulpit. The consistory (sp) there was not impressed and made it plain he must stop teaching on this topic or perhaps if he did not stop, he may have to leave. He continued to teach on this; he was invited to

leave. In the Christian Reformed Church the pastor is hired and can be fired.

Loie and Cal were living in a new parsonage with their seven children. The children were in Christian schools. For Cal to disregard the natural questions of "How am I going to pay all of the needed expenses?" in favor of teaching truth was what made him a hero to me!

Cal would pray for others to receive the baptism in the Holy Spirit experience during the long months that he was waiting for the Lord to give this blessing to him. When he did receive this baptism he said it was a miracle of God taking him from his head experiences to a heart experience.

When he left the Christian Reformed church a man offered to let him and his family to stay in their farm house in Jamestown for free. That farm house had a chicken coop on its property. The strong smell of the chickens was still in that coop. Cal and Loie started meetings in that chicken coop. People came from miles around to attend . That that small place was packed wall to wall. These meetings were glorious!

Watching God work in and through the Bergsmas had a huge impact on my spiritual life.

Cal conducted a meeting at Grandville Middle School around March of 1972 . I got prayed for again to receive the baptism in the Spirit. I had been prayed for many, many times for nine months when I began to seek this for myself . People all around me received and spoke in tongues, but not me. I shamelessly got up into every altar call in hopes that I would receive this Holy Spirit baptism! Now I know that it was good that happened because I can assure seekers to keep seeking and God will answer. People should never give up on a prayer request that is Biblical and the known will of God for us to receive the request. Perhaps if I received it immediately I would be judgmental towards people who did not receive right away. I may have thought that perhaps they were insincere or maybe even in secret sin. But I knew that I was sincere and that I had let God do a deeper work of sanctification in me.

At the Grandville meeting Cal had everyone pray for the person on their left side. The person there to pray for me was the husband of the piano teacher who took me to the meeting where I met Loie, Sherwin Kamps. (sp?)

Nothing happened immediately in that meeting; but, on the way home with my three month old son, E.G, on my lap, while I was singing and driving my singing praises turned into speaking in tongues. Just like that I finally received ! The flowing forth of my new prayer language was strong and powerful ! It happened on 44th st , S.W. in Wyoming right by the vacant lot that in the late 1970's became the home of the First Assembly of God. Years later when Robert and I were members there I saw a plaque showing the charter members of First Assembly. It was a short list. Several of those listed

were my relatives from my birth father's side, the Hoyts and the Fairbairns.

It is quite notable to me that when I questioned why we no longer experienced the power of the Spirit like those in the book of Acts I had never even heard of the Charismatic movement. The fact that thousands all around the world had been seeking the same deeper experience in the Lord at the same time is amazing to me. This taught me that God has special seasons that He operates in strongly to make Himself known to hungry hearts that have asked Him for new revelation and experiences in Him. And, He is the one both stirring up the hunger and the mass movement to satisfy that hunger.

After I had gotten the baptism in the Holy Spirit in 1972, I joined Bethel Pentecostal Church in Grand Rapids and stayed faithfully there until I left in 1975 when I moved to San Diego. Before I joined I used to ride by on Sundays and see the people socializing after a service and I was deeply drawn to what I felt when I saw them.

My neighbor on Bates Street, Sister Jenkins, went to Bethel and encouraged me to visit.

Bethel had an outstanding choir led by James Abney, Elder Abney's brother. Two of my co workers at Social Services, Barb Van Weinen and John O'Conner, invited me to go with them to hear the choir. We went two weeks in a row. I cried a lot during each service I went to. I was moved tremendously by the presence of the Lord I sensed in that church!

John and Barb did not go again after we had gone two weeks in a row. I kept on attending.

I answered the altar call to be baptized there. I believed since I was fourteen that I should be baptized as an adult. I was delighted to discover that Bethel had a baptismal pool along with robes to wear to get into the water. I was baptized on the spot. I came out of the water with great joy! I literally felt the presence of the Lord and His pleasure in what I had finally done!

I had been baptized at First Byron Center Christian Reformed Church when I was one year old when my adoption was final . According to their belief the infants can be baptized if they were children of covenant people, believers. As long as I was not legally belonging to the Herms, I was not eligible to be baptized.

When I was fourteen I went to the office of our pastor at my Byron Center church, Dr. H. De Wolf , to let him know I was reading the Bible where it says in Acts 2: Then Peter said unto them, Repent, and be baptized every one of you in the name of Jesus Christ for the remission of sins, and ye shall receive the gift of the Holy Ghost.

I told him I no longer thought it was appropriate to baptize infants. How could an infant "Repent"? He looked at me and asked, "Do you have a boy friend? Do you go to movies?" A total non sequitur (which Websters says one definition is :

A statement (such as a response) that does not follow logically from or is not clearly

related to anything previously said.

He never did respond to my statement about infant baptism! I realize that this transaction between us was so preposterous that it is hard to believe it actually happened. I was there. It happened!

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I returned to Bethel as soon as I moved back home from San Diego in 1976. When I first joined Bethel they were meeting on the corner of Sherman and Eastern SE. When I came back they had moved to 200 Madison SE . In January of 1976, the first Sunday I was there after coming back from San Diego, a man came up to my sister , Shelly, and me and invited us to a Bible study in his parent's home where he was living at that time. We attended. The group of people meeting there were all from Bethel . Our meetings became so full of the presence of the Lord that we got together every single night that we were not in church! We were all careful not to skip church meetings. But our meetings apart from the church services were on fire! These meeting lasted nonstop for three months! Sometimes we stayed until the wee hours of the morning together and then went out to a restaurant to eat breakfast!

In those meetings we prayed together, listened to teaching tapes, praised the Lord in song, and cast out a lot of demons.

We met at the homes of Robert Barnes, Cathy Barrows , and George Patterson.

Robert Barnes

One night at Cathy's home the man who had initially invited me to the meetings, Robert Barnes, told the whole group that he believed God sent me back to Michigan from California to marry him.

Remember that I wrote that I did not want to ever get married again? I told Robert that. He said, "It is not good for man to be alone". I said, "That is your problem , you are the man". Then he tried another strategy to win my heart. He would call me on the phone in the morning, pray for me , and hang up. That tactic touched me and definitely got my attention.

I started to look at and examine him more closely. He always looked so handsome, well dressed, and he smelled of cologne. He sang beautifully. Noticing his soothing speaking voice and his kind ways added to my growing attraction to him.

After a couple of weeks I "let my guard down" and changed my mind about being with him to get to know him better.

Happily I can tell you that from the time I returned from California in January of 1976 to this moment, October 18 , 2021, there has been no other man for me but him. Finally I had become free from wrongful relationships with men.

We were married on 10 8 76. We recently celebrated our 45rd anniversary.

Nearly immediately after our marriage we started teaching adult Sunday School at Bethel. Not long thereafter we held chapel services at the juvenile detention center as well as prayer meetings at the 700 club facility in town. We would also have Bible studies in our home. We did a lot of deliverance and counseling in our home at that time too.

Both Robert and I came into our marriage with leftover "baggage" from our first marriages. Robert was married to his pastor's daughter in Niles, Michigan. They had a son, Jonathan , together. Jonathan is just six months older than E.G.

Because this is my story here and not his, I will not take the time to get deep into reporting the situation that led to her filing for divorce from him. His situation concerning his ex wife,Sherry, is quite personal and for him to chose to share, not me . They were divorced quite some time before he and I started our relationship.

I have already written about my marriage to Louie. The problem was that if Robert did anything remotely related to something Louie had done that hurt me, I would fly into a tirade about how I don't need a man. I was moody. I went to a dark hole of rejection frequently. I needed help!

But, in spite of all the spiritual warfare swirling in the atmosphere surrounding our heads, we could enter into a place of being able to minister to others effectively without

splashing our muddy water aspects all over them.

Robert often would lead in some of the praise times at Bethel. He attempted to introduce into this black gospel singing church the "new" songs from the charismatic movement – considered "white" at Bethel – to the congregation. He was disappointed in how they responded to these attempts. He got to the point he wanted to go somewhere in closer harmony with the Charismatic movement. Bethel came from the stream of churches generated from the revival at the turn of the 20th century. The Charismatic movement started in the 1960's among mainline denominations, including the Catholics.

So we started going regularly to a charismatic church, Maranatha. This church evolved from the Bergsma's and their chicken coop meetings. Some other people who were Charismatic pioneers in the movement joined in with them too. They actually did not call themselves a church while we were there. They were a fellowship. They had six elders as their leaders. Cal was a strong elder among elders. I believe Cal had the strongest pastoral anointing among all the other elders and the boldest leadership abilities.

The praise and worship at Marantha went on each time for at least and hour. Then followed an "open pulpit " time in which anyone in the room could get up and share a teaching, sing, testify, prophesy, or do any thing they believed the Lord was leading them to do. I used this opportunity many, many times to share what the Lord was showing me in the Word. The leadership rarely if ever interfered with what was going on in this part of the service. Sometimes they did bring in a guest speaker. Because there was not special teaching or groups that targeted the little ones, I began to desire something especially for E.G. so he could be presented with Bible truths appropriate to his age and understanding.

We did not leave Maranatha with any negative attitude and did continue to visit from time to time after we left. (The same can be said about our relationship with Bethel.)

We visited First Assembly of God. They had just built a new church building on 44 th St. in Wyoming. Remember I wrote that I received the baptism in the Holy Spirit on 44th St. right in front of the lot where First Assembly was built? That was significant to me when Robert whispered to me in the first service we visited , "I think this is the church the Lord wants us to go to" . I did not want to become members of that church. I know the Word well enough to know that if my husband says "This is our church" and sticks to it even after my presenting some objections, that is where I , as his wife, was to go with him. The Bible is very clear on wive's submitting to their husbands .

Why was my first response to object going to First Assembly? For one thing, it was huge. It seemed formal even compared to Bethel with all her traditions . At Maranatha I had gotten used to calling all the leaders by their first names. The atmosphere was free

and easy. We could all share what the Lord had shown us without having to get permission from someone to stand up and speak into the microphone to the entire congregation. At First Assembly everyone seemed so “perfect”. I feared my rough edges would be discovered and I would be rejected by these folks. All that was presented was carefully planned. Something unexpected and unplanned rarely happened. I again felt stifled and also unable to conform to what seemed to be some behavioral norm.

Surprisingly, all things considered, our year there was highly profitable for us and , hopefully, for them too.

The pastor, Wayne Benson, became one of my main role models in regard to being loving but very strong. He was musically gifted and he taught in depth and clarity. I grew to respect him deeply.

After we joined, I was amazed when Pastor Benson himself approached Robert and me and asked us if were were willing to become the leaders of a College and Career Class being newly formed. We said , “Yes”. By that time we had taught together at Juvenile Court Detention , at Bethel, and led a prayer meeting with many adults present using the 700 Club as our venue. A couple of chairs and a table were placed for Robert and me in the lobby so that before and after the services we could get young people to sign up for our class .
We taught that class for a year. We met some wonderful young people . We are still friends with some of them.

As an effort to keep myself from feeling too constricted , I asked if we could create our own weekly lessons rather than use anyone else’s prepared material. We were told “yes” but we were required to hand in our printed lesson each week to Pastor Myers, an associate minister there. We did this faithfully ; however, I still wonder if he read our lessons. He never did comment on any one of them.

When First Assembly published an 50th Anniversary booklet quite some time after we left, they put our picture and the fact we had left to start a church in that publication. Because of Pastor Benson’s sterling reputation I felt we were highly honored by his including us that way! Some who slandered us and said we “left in rebellion” were forced to face that we were telling the truth that we had sat in his office telling him the vision God gave us to start a church and he gave us his blessing.

We start a church, Grand Rapids River of Life Ministries

In 1976 I began to get some revelation from the Lord about Ephesians 4: 11 to 15 . I saw the fivefold ministry's purpose to "perfect the saints for the work of the ministry" as well as the principle of "speaking the truth in love ". These were two principles I did not see in place anywhere at that time. (Since then we have met many who have Ephesians 4 as a major emphasis in their church.) The five fold ministry offices are listed in Ephesians 4 as well as the goal of all he ministry work of the church: Ephesians 4: 11
And he gave some, apostles; and some, prophets; and some, evangelists; and some, pastors and teachers; **12** For the perfecting of the saints, for the work of the ministry, for the edifying of the body of Christ:

13 Till we all come in the unity of the faith, and of the knowledge of the Son of God, unto a perfect man, unto the measure of the stature of the fulness of Christ:

14 That we *henceforth* be no more children, tossed to and fro, and carried about with every wind of doctrine, by the sleight of men, *and* cunning craftiness, whereby they lie in wait to deceive; 15But speaking the truth in love, may grow up into him in all things, which is the head, *even* Christ:

I realized that the job of the pastor was to make sure each person came forth in the ministry that they were called to do. The goal of all ministry ultimately is for people to grow up into Christ.

Throughout my formative years in church I did see some in leadership doing the jobs they were called to do ; but, I believe the vast majority of people in the church were onlookers during services or even in the overall church operation. Seldom was every member of the church family encouraged to discover what spiritual gifts and callings they had to fulfill. The preacher in my childhood church even did the song leading. Praise teams with a band did not yet exist anywhere that we had ever been to. Seldom , if ever, did we hear from members of the congregation any testimonies of what the Lord was doing in their lives or what He was showing them in the Word . Never did I have the challenge presented to me concerning coming forth in whatever spiritual gifts or service I felt could be mine to give.

Of course , some were Sunday School teachers or youth leaders. These people made a big impact on my life because they were loving and faithful.

To grow well we need to speak the truth in love to one another.

"Speaking the truth in love" is an action I have always longed to see. The culture I was raised in avoided any conversation that could result in words that would provoke a dialogue that got too passionate. Confrontation was rare. Sharing disagreements was avoided. Talking about anything too controversial was not done. I have always been curious about the perspective of others and even liked to debate about various points of view.

I say "debate", not "argue". There is a huge difference. Very few people are able to present an opposing view to another person and proceed to discuss it in a reasonable, objective fashion as one would do in a formal debate .

When I was a student at South Christian High I watched my first debate. A young lady named Lois Hiemstra was speaking with clarity and obvious advanced intellectual ability. I was totally dazzled by her "performance". I joined the debating team myself. I stayed on a debating team all three years at South Christian and then two more years at Calvin.

To see women "debating" without getting into emotional responses but rather sticking objectively to truth using appropriate quotations and logic to reinforce their points caused me to want this kind of mature dialogue in conversations outside of a debate team exercise.

I see "debating" as one form of speaking the truth in love.

An honest debate should be a sharing of perceived truths with a goal of coming closer to the truth. Precious few people are willing to share what they believe to be true in a patient, loving fashion if someone else is not agreeing with their point of view. Part of growing up into Christ is learning how to freely, openly, lovingly speak the truth in love as it states in Ephesians 11:15.

I have personally witnessed and then also heard about pastors who take on ministerial affectations and deliberate distancing from others who are not pastors so as to position themselves as the official truth holder and practice intimidation tactics towards anyone daring to question their expertise on all things Bible . For example, Robert brought a revelation he had to one of his pastors when he was young and was told that the Lord would not give him, Robert, a revelation that He would not first show to the pastor.

There was a group of people in the Bible that were praised simply because they went back to study if what they were taught was in harmony with the Word of God. They are spoken of in Acts 17: And the brethren immediately sent
away Paul and Silas by night unto Berea: who coming *thither* went into the synagogue of the Jews. **Act 17:11** These were more noble than those in Thessalonica, in that

they received the word with all readiness of mind, and searched the scriptures daily, whether those things were so.

To this day I still tell the people I preach to about these Bereans they should imitate! I ,nor anyone else, should not totally believe every commentary on the Word that the five fold ministry speaks; we need to study for ourselves to confirm the Word! I tell people to let me know if they find anything in the Word that would contradict what I am saying. To do this we all need to learn to "rightly divide the Word" (2 Timothy 2:15). We must often weigh in on many passages in order to find the full truth. To do this and to share openly with one another takes humility because we risk being shown when we may be mistaken. Sometimes our ego cannot handle an idea we expressed being openly proven wrong. But we must love truth much more that we love our public image!

I wondered where there might be a church who endeavored to conform to this Ephesians passage . In late 1979 the Lord said to me "What's that in your hand, Moses?" I knew He meant for me to do something about putting in place what I saw in Ephesians 4.

I told my husband, Robert, that I believe the Lord was calling us to start a church. He did not hesitate to agree. Having lived many more decades since that moment, I now realize what a rare person Robert is that his wife could basically say, "Let's start a church" and he responded with a "Yes, let's". I thank God for a husband filled with the Holy Spirit and willing to go on a bold adventure not knowing at the time who might join us when we started our church! E.G. was living with us so we knew we had at least one member. At that time too the Lord showed me, in an inner vision, water rising on the streets of Grand Rapids. The origin of the water flowed from Fountain St. Church. That particular church was not the point, it's name was the point. There was to be a fountain of water, the Holy Spirit, flowing forth into Grand Rapids which would bring forth an ever flowing river. At that time the song "There's a River of Life flowing out of me" was popular so between that river rising vision and the song I thought of the name "River of Life Ministries" for our church. At that time I had never heard of a church called by that name. Now that name is found a lot in the USA and in some other countries too!

The lyrics of the river song are: **There's a river of life flowing out of me,**
Makes the lame to walk
and the blind to see.
Open prison door sets the captive free,
There's a river of life flowing out of me.

The idea for the song comes from John 7:38: He that believeth on me, as the scripture hath said, out of his belly shall flow rivers of living water. 39 (But this spake he of the Spirit, which they that believe on him should receive: for the Holy Ghost was not yet *given*; because that Jesus was not yet glorified.)

In December 1979 we called a group of leader friends into our living room to explain what we were about to do. Our friend, Loie Bergsma was present. (That was an information session – we knew all of them were firmly established in their own churches and were not expecting them to come to our church.)

A woman named Vi Vander Linde was present. When she perceived we were just a little shy about calling what we were about to do a church and saying that we were the pastors, she encouraged us to immediately establish that fact ,openly and boldly. I was so glad for her Godly advice. I can see why people could be tempted to say less emphatic plans like , "Well, we will start out as a Bible study to see who comes. Then we will ask the people if they want to help start a church and agree for us to be the pastors." We would have started out in weakness had we done that !

Then on the first Saturday night following that meeting, on 1 5 80, we started the church. We knew of absolutely no one who was coming only Robert, our son, E.G, a few days short of aged eight at that time, and myself. Miraculously there was never a time when no one showed up. This January, 2022, we will be celebrating our 41stth church anniversary.

Within a few years I started a leadership and ministry school to train ministers. The school continues to this day. All of our pastors presently at River of Life went through this school. The school can be four years unless a student does part time work and then it can last a lot longer. The Bible is our textbook. The church and our lives are the hands on learning places.

Last weekend my husband and I attended his 61st year Dowagiac, Michigan high school reunion. On the Saturday we were absent the current ministry class students took charge of every aspect of both services. They have informed me that all went very well and they had fun doing this.

Normally members who graduated years ago from the school who are our present leadership team are selected to take charge when we are absent.

To raise up ministers in an in house school assures us that the vision for what a church should be will be carried on by those we train.

We continued to conduct our church in our home for about four years.

I find it amusing when I hear of someone starting a church needing a certain amount of money, people, and equipment.

When we started we nearly nothing by way of "equipment". I don't remember how we

got this, but our “pulpit” was made of fruit crates and the place where we put our papers had a sign that said , “Keep dry”.

I went to an estate sale where I found eleven padded folding chairs to add to our living and dining room furniture when we met.

Susan Parsons, now Susan Sumner_____, had been one of our students at First Assembly whom we had gotten really close to. We deliberately started having services on Saturday nights so as not to “steal” any sheep from anyone else if they chose to visit us but belonged to another church. Susan had been a singer in Nashville, Tennesse before coming to Michigan. She donated her excellent sound equipment to our church and also played the piano already in our livingroom when we had praise time.

Robert and I were not poor . I was still at Social services and he was a maintenance contractor when we started the church. I kept working as a social worker and a pastor the first four years of our having a church.

We provided a meal for the entire group after each Saturday evening service. Then we would hang out together and talk often until well past midnight.

We never had one service in which no one came. We certainly did not work hard at going around asking people to join us. They simply came from different places .

The services in our home were as precious as any I have ever been to in a mainline, prosperous , large church. Our “format” include praise and worship, teaching , and personal ministry. Because we were small we would ask the person who requested spiritual help to share with the whole group what ministry they needed and , therefore, everyone either got involved first hand or witnessed all the ministry that person received. That was true even if we needed to cast out a demon. Everyone could see exactly how we went about the deliverance, could hear the responses even if it was screaming or crying that happened, and rejoice together when the person was freed. This way we became an extraordinarily close group in which no one had to be ashamed because of what happened in front of everyone that may have exposed what some would have perceived as a weakness to gossip about. Today we do most all deliverances in very small groups rather than in front of the entire congregation. But then the complete open , loving, caring atmosphere that made it possible for such intimacy was precious .

Becoming a shepherd after being a lost sheep demanded a big transition of how I saw myself. Although we had done quite a bit of ministry work, being senior pastors was another level of responsibility.

We were in a time when we were just coming out of what was known as the “shepherding” movement. This movement had some marvelous teachers whom most all of us in the charismatic circles listened to regularly . We trusted them. But they evolved

into some teachings that were extremely harmful to the body of Christ (for which later this group of leaders repented).

This movement gave way to much power to the pastors in the personal life choices of the church members. Even more damaging was their position on women in the home and in ministry. Such an emphasis was put on the position of the husband that some started to teach that the woman should wait until dad gets home from work if their child needed prayer. This harmful lie probably influenced a future common and incorrect belief that the husband was the priest of the home. The husband is the head of the wife and together they are the authority over their children; but , every believer is a priest in Christ. Every believer can go directly and boldly to the throne of the Lord, the holy of holies to bring petitions to the Lord. Even an eleven year old child in the home is a priest if he is a believer.

Then some started saying the husband is the "high priest". We have one high priest who is the Lord Jesus Christ.

The need for the men being elevated and the women being put in their place was rampant to the extent that if a woman was bold and capable of managing some areas of life she was suspected of having a "spirit of Jezebel". I am sure the internet is still place anyone could learn more about that, I will just say that being a woman who is her husband's pastor and her husband is her pastor was not easy during that time! Yes, I am the "pastor's wife"; but, he is also the "pastor's husband". Try to find a greeting card even today that is a birthday card for the "pastor's husband". It is much easier to find the one "For our pastor's wife".

Many came to our church accepting
Robert's authority but resisting mine. One guy actually tossed a teddy bear up in the air repeatedly while I taught one night. He made it clear that a woman was not supposed to be teaching me. I always wondered what would inspire a man to come repeatedly to River of Life if he believed a woman should not be a pastor.

Years ago we both got a call from the Total Christian Television station for us to both be a part of the program "Ask the Pastor". Robert did a few and did not really enjoy doing it. But I did that program very regularly (usually a couple times a month) for over twenty five years. Throughout all those years there were only around five or so other women pastors . Most of them stayed less than a year. At first it seemed an uphill battle for me because the question was continually given to me in rather teasing manner if someone was asking about women's right to preach. One male host when I answered would look at his watch within seconds after I started talking . I never saw him do that when the men would answer. There was another host who said to all the others when I lifted my finger to indicate I would like to respond to a question, "Should we let her answer". This was often aired nationally and internationally. I had to closely guard my responses to what I

considered some subtle discrimination again me because I was a woman. This same pastor who asked if I should be allowed to answer walked out when a station manager was hired and she exercised her authority when she addressed us one day. She was very sensitive to the Holy Spirit. She led us with wisdom and kindness all the while walking gracefully in the authority that had been given to her.

Eventually they called on me to host programs sometimes. One male pastor when he first met me and found out I was hosting proceeded to tell me what questions in the pack of questions that I should use. That was always considered the host's job to choose . i

I would come home after the TV program was finished and tell Robert of what battles I faced that day. Robert did not sympathize with me whatsoever. He told me that those other pastors were not the ones inviting me to do the program and to ignore whatever jabs they made to remind me I was a woman and I needed to know "my place". He has always encouraged me to stay strong and confident in what the Lord has given to me to do and to not be moved by the opinions of others.

Eventually I realized that it was useless to try to persuade men in our church or anywhere I went to minister that I had a call from God to do what I was doing. God showed me that my job was to do what he placed me to do as excellently as I possibly could. If any man was to be persuaded that I was doing God's will, that was the way they would see it. If someone did not agree with me doing this, disregard that and keep on working to build up His kingdom. With Robert's coaching and this rather simple but profound to me word from the Lord, I gradually overcame the battles I perceived and had taken seriously and learned to ignore those who thought I was "out of order".

Sometimes as a shepherd, a pastor, I must remind myself firmly that I will be a target of much slander, gossip, and misunderstanding and to know that God's soldiers determine to walk through all these "attacks" with strength and courage.

The goal is to bring people into the knowledge of the Lord and to help them become mature productive Christians. To quit aiming for this goal because my feelings get hurt is not pleasing to the Lord!

Even though we have a building and land today, I often say that our church is still like a house church even though we meet now in a church building. At the house we established interactive teaching, praying for one another, a time of testimonies , eating meals together each week, being strong in praise and worship, and being strong in communicating with each other. All these characteristics remain today.

The role of prophecy in our ministry

We received many prophetic words over the years. One of the first was about international outreach. We were still in the house when we got that word. I was still working full time at Social Services. Our church was very small. My first thought was, "How would we ever afford the plane tickets?" But the Lord over the years provided! Often Robert has come with me; however, more often than not I have gone alone to many nations to minister. I have now been to minster in Belgium around 17 times, in Argentina around 7 times, in France, in Bulgaria, in Israel, in Canada, in Honduras, at least 8 times in Mexico , in Guatemala, in the Dominican Republic, and in Zimbabwe, Africa. God has provided for each ministry trip.

The trip to Zimbabwe was the most expensive. Even today the 3,500.00 ticket is a lot. The price caused me to hesitate to accept the invitation to minister there. Then the grandpa of one of our ministers died. She gave out of her inheritance from him the exact price of that ticket, 3,500.00 . I understood that provision as God's green light to go to Africa to minister.

Another prophetic word I got is that I would be on TV. That was in the very early '90's. Within weeks I got a call from Herb Smith, the then station manager at TCT TV, who asked me to be on "Ask the Pastor". I was also an interviewer quite a few times for "Michigan Alive".

About the same time that we got that prophesy about doing TV we had been asked to come and minister in a church in Marquette, Michigan. We met a lady named Betty there and were in her home to see the cable TV station setup in her basement. She was a pioneer in that area in cable so those who wanted to start a program in the Marquette area were sent to her for some instruction on how to go about setting up a program. Seeing her whole operations inspired me to go back home and start a teaching program called "River Reflections" at our local cable station. A staff from church and I have been doing that now for over 25 years. That is one ministry I truly need and appreciate a faithful staff to help! I could not do that one alone.

Another prophetic word we both got from Bill Hamon a few decades ago said that we

would both have a free flow of prophecy , that there would be times we would be able to give everyone in the room a prophetic word. That word has been respoken by the Holy Spirit to me often . He reminds me He has equipped me and prods me on to walk in what He has place in me!

Having experienced the power of the prophetic word in my own life motivated me to covet and deeply appreciate this gift. The Lord has given Robert and me many prophetic words for many people – especially during international travel. I think being in a place where the people know we don't know their personal situation draws this prophetic gift more strongly from us. We know that no one can think that someone else in the church told us about everyone's lives and that is why we seem to be prophesying accurately to them .

In fact, when we would have a prophetess named Linda Sutter come to our church, we made it a point to not say anything about how anyone in the church was doing because we did not even want one hint that we might be feeding her information ahead of time that she could use in her ministry to the people. After she was done ministering then we would often affirm to her delight how accurately the Lord had used her. I have learned to appreciate it when someone extends that courtesy to me because my faith in what the Lord is saying to me is strengthened when the leaders confirms some things after a service is over.

I have chosen to give examples of some of the prophetic words given to us that have impacted the ministry. I also cherish but will not take the time to record the words that have been healing personally and enhanced my own walk with the Lord. Pastors need ministry too!

Music

Robert and I are both musicians. We both play trumpet. He plays the saxophone. I play keyboard. We both sing (me harmony, him lead – he is a wonderful soloist too). What is really special to us are the trumpets. It was two years into our marriage when I bought a trumpet from a garage sale. He said, "Do you play trumpet?" I said, "Yes". I asked did he play too. He said, "Yes". And he added, "If you are going to play with me you have to play by ear". That took some time for me to do that. But he made a demand on me over the years to follow whatever he is doing; therefore, I have taken my trumpet along to the nations and played by ear with scores of praise bands. At our church praise and worship remains a major joy to us! We both play and sing in each and every service along with many other musicians and singers the Lord has blessed us with...

Tell about the silver trumpets

Remember I said Pastor Stilwell ended up being a blessing to me? Actually, to our church. Months after we started the church he called and said that the Lord had been speaking to him about ordaining us both as well as making our church a subsidiary of Home Ministry Fellowship. Neither becoming ordained nor becoming a nonprofit corporation had occurred to either of us. We were simply excited about our vision for doing church. Of course, both ended up being valuable to us! We had to be a nonprofit corporation to buy buildings and land. Being ordained helps credibility with man and gives entrée to many places. So he did ordain us both and we did become a nonprofit corporation (we did a separate action with the State of Michigan too). Until Pastor Stilwell's death, I sent quarterly reports to him and he and his wife would come to visit our church from time to time. He also had Robert and me to go out West to be speakers at the HMF conventions. After both he and his wife he died, the board of directors, at Chuck and Susan Stilwell's home in Sierra Vista, Arizona, voted for me to become the

president. This was a lifetime appointment so I remain the president today.

The person whom I met at the Stilwell who was the California resident on our Home Ministry Fellowship annual report form, asked me what was my five year plan for the ministry. He was a successful business man . I had been taught at Social Services the planning tool called "Management by Obectives" so I immediately recognized his particul frame of reference for success in managing an organization. I could not possible state a management out come goal for any ministry I am directing! Whatever works for others does not work for me! Mine path is more like Paul's in Acts 9:6, the first part of the verse: 6 And he trembling and astonished said, Lord, what wilt thou have me to do? KJV

The question, "What wilt thou have me to do?" is a regular prayer request for me. Sometimes I get an overall plan that will take quite awhile, e.g., writing this book, and other times it is something to do that very day. I follow whatever the Lord says. In looking backwards I can see and often understand the reasons and the results of His instructions. For me to sit down today and write our my goals and both what and when I am going to do the steps towards my goals, I do not get that specific because the Lord has been my schedule guide all these years.

A couple of years ago our South Christian High School Class President, Rich Schrotenboer, contacted me to let me know the reunion planning committee wanted me to do a short time of sharing after we all eat together. The theme, he said, was "God's Guidance". In connection with preparing the little "speech", I began to think of all the many songs we sing regarding this theme because he asked me to lead a song too. Of course I immediately delegated my song leading to Robert who is seasoned in that area of ministry. Some songs many Christians sing are: "Where He Leads Me I will Follow", "Savior like a Shepherd Lead us", and "We've come this far by Faith, Leaning on the Lord" . Those songs have lyrics that are a vital part of my day to day testimony about being a pastor and leader! Moses told God that he did not even want to keep going forward unless he was assured that God was with him!

Another song that comes to mind, "Without Him I would be Nothing" and some of the lyrics are , "without Him I would be drifting, like a ship without a sail". I know better than to map a course to follow, announce to everyone, "This is what we will have accomplished within five years", and then do some sort of prayer that says, "God, please cause my plans to succeed". A big part of the walk of faith is to simply move at God's guidance when you know where the path will end or not.

That got me thinking about the many song's we could sing: Savior like a Shepherd lead us, where He leads me I will follow, We've come this far by Faith, oh God you are my

God and I will ever…you,,, and step by step He will lead me.

As I wrote already, the River of Life brochure including “goals” and “methods” to achieve those goals was led by the Spirit and written by me in the 1980’s. Many things written at that time were preposterous considering both people and financial resources. But, over time, most all of what was in those lists have been accomplished . Did I know then how or when the Lord was going to lead us into certain areas of service? No. Did I know how many years it would be before some activities would come forth? No.

That ministry board consisted of around fifteen or so people deliberated a long time before appointing me as president . Several present had seen the ministry in days of ministry camps where a couple of hundred people were present, the existence of quite a few ministers ordained by the group as well as churches that were a subsidiary (like us) of the ministry. The mailing list had six hundred people on it. I actually had no concept of the state of the ministry when I took office . The founders were both well up in age when they died; most all of their “followers” were also in their elderly years. Many on that mailing list were Stilwell relatives . When I began to sort through all the names on that list, what emerged as still active Home Ministry Fellowship people did not number over one hundred.

The Stilwells had put out a montly Newsletter so I proceeded to accept that responsibility. At first I would send it to Chuck for “proofreading”, more for the content than grammar and spelling. We would spend quite a bit of time communicating about what he thought would interest the group versus what I thought they might (or even “should”) be interested in. After I found out who exactly I was dealing with , I began to realize that what was with the Stilwells had passed and I needed to evaluate Home Ministry Fellowship with new eyes. I stopped writing the newsletters.

I did arrange and host a few annual gatherings , maybe six in all. I was allowed to use an Assembly of God church in Sunizona , Arizona a couple of times, I rented a facility from Cochise College in Arizona a couple of times, and we also, I believe, had a couple of meetings in Chuck and Susan’ And we did experience wonderful times. However, I also knew that a good deal of the “core group” from the past also met weekly at Chuck and Susan’s home and did keep in touch with one another in various ways. It seemed to me that what once was the backbone members of “Home Ministry Fellowship” had become those who still met together at the Stilwell’s home. One couple, The Inman’s , had a church in a mobile home in Arizona and therefore needed the ongoing membership in Home Ministry Fellowship to maintain their IRS legal status. Actually some of the last meetings I organized were more for their benefit than anything else since they were the only ones left actually pastoring a church. They are now retired and in their nineties. We

have occasional communication but not much.

The most valuable aspect of Home Ministry Fellowship right now for us is the fact we remain a subsidiary of that ministry for IRS purposes.

I realize I could “drum up” an entire new fellowship of people to “recruit” to become a part of this group and resurrect past activites; however, I don’t sense any leading from the Lord in that direction. I am just grateful River of Life does not have an urgent need to get a 501 © status on our own because we have it through Home Ministry Fellowship.

I learned a lot from my more active times in actually being with the people from Home Ministry Fellowship. A couple of lessons are: It is painful for people to eliminate their estimation of a group that was formed decades before in order to examine , “Where are we at right now?” To face the fact that what was is no more is difficult. To realize that we continue to experience strong ties that bind us together in love , but no one can recreate what once was in the strong , ongoing meetings , programs, and summer conventions and camps we once experienced is difficult to deal with. Ministries can become very different from what the founders put in place!

Another thing I learned: Having the position of president does not come close to being Bobbie and Charles Stilwell who forged lifelong relationships in meetings , personal ministry , counseling, prayers, sharing joy and sorrow together in a very personal way, and being “Mom and Dad “ to hundreds of people who the Lord gave them to love and nurture. (I am one of them.) No one can take the place of these two . No one can resurrect the “glory days” from many decades of that ministry. Perhaps the sooner we learn this, the better! When a new pastor comes in , we need to learn it is a new day and that pastor may put a new vision and way of “doing church” in place! Burdens are unnecessarily put on newcomers if “That is the way we always did things and you need to do it that way too” is the constant theme of “old timers”. I thank God that once I explained what I discovered about the state of Home Ministry Fellowship to the others involved, no one nagged me or condemned me to no longer issuing the newsletter or holding yearly get togethers. To examine and declare these things, however, produced some anxiety in me. I come from a background that does expect certain things from the pastor they hire! Much of the expectations that come from traditions that have been in place for hundreds of years!

One of our polices is to always “follow the Lamb wherever He goes”. (Revelation 14:4). I will discuss more about that later. It is almost impossible to follow both God and men’s extra-Biblical traditions and expectations! Even if these non Biblical mandates served a group well , we always have to allow new leaders to get in touch with the Lord’s direction for their leadership without demanding they follow the path of someone else!

Perhaps I ultimately led Home Ministry Fellowship to a place of rest when I realized what

is was when I got it. Perhaps those who had been active for decades in this work would have been too subjective to face and own what needed to happen for us all to move on.

There is another principle I learned both from Home Ministry Fellowship and from River of Life: Man seems to think every ministry must last generation after generation and must be continually growing (think numbers of people) to be a "success". I see that God uproots and plants people to produce fruit. Those that eat that spiritual fruit then around to be used in the uprooting and planting process. God actually knows precisely what faithful servant did in their part to build His kingdom and is not concerned about the "success " of an individual work as much as the "success" of the kingdom being built up all of the world by many nameless, faceless (to the rest of the world) people who are faithfully responding to what He is asking and directing them to do.

For example, if I train a person in ministry and start to imagine what a help they will be to our local church, then I might be disappointed if they move to another city and either start or join a work there. If I make River of Life my own little kingdom, I have lost vision of the fact we are all parts of a worldwide body of believers building the kingdom of the Lord. One person may look at our church and say, "They have been around for how many years and have how many people coming?" in a rather mocking fashion. Only the Lord sees all the seeds we planted as a church family together. Only the Lord sees who we have ministered to through the media, through ministry trips, through teaching those who then brought some fresh revelation or zeal to another kingdom work, and even those faithfully still attending River of Life who are lights in their family, work, and community. Our job is to simply do whatever He leads us to do.

I have often used a couple of analogies in referring to "church growth". One is that I would rather have twenty thriving tomato plants in my garden than have a huge field that appears to have hundreds of tomato plants , but upon closer examination we see that ninety of those plants are plastic (placed there to make the farmer look "successful") and only ten living plants.

The other: When the Lord told us to start a church, in effect, He handed us a seed to plant and nurture. He knew exactly what kind of tree that this seed would produce. Some are given a seed that will grow into a huge pine tree. Others may have a seed that grows up to be a dwarf apple tree. To compare the trees and say one is better than the other would be a false statement. All that needs to happen for that seed to grow up and be perfectly acceptable is for the seed to become what it was intented by the Lord to become.

There are churches that are huge that capitalize on the initial entry into the Lord through salvation; there are other churches whose theme is to train members to go deep into the things of the Lord and to go forth in various ways to teach others. There are some meant to major in community care; others are apostolic centers that frequently bring leaders together to be encouraged and enpowered for ministry – that church will have frequent

seminars and conventions . The time , money, and energy demanded in hosting these events will consume much of the membership. They are meeting their purpose which is all the Lord requires of each work.

As a pastor, my concern is to follow the Lord for our assignment. How that looks to everyone on the outside of our church family cannot be my concern. I believe many a shepherd has wasted much time to be both what is considered in his community "successful" in church work as well as straining to hear and to do the unique calling of his church.

My dear husband, Robert

Around 2000 my husband, Robert, started telling me to get a doctorate in ministry.

In order for you to appreciate his pushing me to do this, there are some things you should know about Robert.

He has dyslexia. We "diagnosed " it ourselves through reading about what this is. Years after we figured this out, Robert actually went to a neurologist who confirmed our diagnosis.

Why he went to a neurologist in the first place was not to find that out but rather to prove to our life insurance company that he was not becoming senile.

The company had some young girl "testing" him on the telephone. She would state a list of numbers or a math problem for him to repeat or to solve. I could hear what was going on and I realized that young lady would attempt some ridiculous analysis of Robert based on those tests. Sure enough, our life insurance premium went way up based on their opinion based on those test results that Robert was losing his cognitive skills.

I asked our insurance representive whether they would lessen the payments if I took him to a neurologist to disprove their (hasty, amateur) diagnosis. He said , "Yes".

So we went to the neurologist who confirmed the dyslexia. I sent the report to the insurance agent. He never responded; the payments stayed at the higher rate.

But, at least we were affirmed in what we already assumed: He indeed had dyslexia.

This learning disability kept him from going past the ninth grade. The disability caused him to lose the cherished esteem he received as an athlete at Dowagiac High School. He played many sports; but , his specialty was football. Once he got put off the team for low grades, he felt like he was invisible to the coach and the players with whom he once felt

favored by and was a part of their circle of athletic friends.

His class of 1960 went on to graduate without him . He was left thinking they saw him as backward. Dyslexia was not something commonly recognized by teachers back then so they did not know how to deal with a student with this learning disability. much less deal with to educate the student successfully in spite of that learning disability.

The custom was too that if you did not graduate, then you do not go to the class reunions. Robert always loved his classmates and truly wanted to know how they were doing from time to time. So he felt especially left out with this added stigma of not being able to attend the reunions.

One happy ending to the reunion issue: We took a trip to Dowagiac about six or so years ago and he decided that we should go visit one of his favorite teachers. I believe her name was Theda Matthews. Her husband was the founder , benefactor of a local college there. When we visited them they treated us like royalty! Mr. Matthews took us on a tour of the college and also told us all about development in Dowagiac. Then he said we would all go out to eat together but only if we let him pay. In the course of our precious visit, Robert shared his desire to go to reunions. After we left them, Theda got on the phone as soon as she could and contacted one of his classmates. That classmate made sure Robert got on the invitation list from then on. We have now gone to two of his class reunions. At both of them he had an opportunity to both say a few words and to sing a gospel song. The second reunion was held last week. The favor towards him was tangible. It felt like both a party and a family reunion. This acceptance and acknowledgement of being a fellow student in that class has been healing to Robert.

I share this because I have just written that he started to encourage me to get my doctorate. How many men do you know who have not even graduated from high school who would want their wife to earn a doctorate? How many men want their wife to excel them quite a bit in any category of life?

I know this is a manifestation of the Spirit of God within Him! Jesus himself calls the church his bride and says to her, John 14:

12 Verily, verily, I say unto you, He that believeth on me, the works that I do shall he do also; and greater works than these shall he do; because I go unto my Father.KJV Jesus also bestowed upon His church all the grace, fruits, and gifts she needs to be able to walk in supernatural power and character. Jesus wants His bride to shine! His bride shining gives Him glory.

So many men think of “headship” over the wife as something that will give them recognition while she says, “I’m just a housewife” or he makes sure she never upstages him .

I've read accounts of illiterate men who became enraged when their wife wanted to learn to read. What would he look like if she could read and he could not? People don't realize that to make other people become tall makes them look even taller.

We have had men come to our church, recognize how Robert encourages me to go forth and walk in all God has given me to be and do. Their response should be to emulate him. Instead the response of a few has been passive aggressive attempts to "even the score" between Robert and me. E.g., give only him eye contact when they give an open pulpit, tell him he gave a good sermon but rarely say that to me after I teach, repeat and praise some advice Robert gave when I was the one who first said it, and invite Robert to come to speak but ignore me. More than that, I have come to discern and even feel that spirit when it rises up to make sure men are united in protecting one another from strong , confident, assertive, productive women.

What is delightful to me is that Robert, although very laid back and kind in the midst of this dynamic, fully discerns those same manipulative moves and is not impressed at all by this. Even more delightful is the fact he is confident in his place in the body of Christ and in our marriage. He really does not need some guy to perceive my strength and help him, Robert , to make sure I stay "in my place", their corrupt view of what that place should be for every wife.

I am so very grateful for my husband's strength and security! He has successfully cultivated me to be productive in ways I never knew I could serve. Sometimes he assumes I can do something well when I wonder where he got the thought that I could! And then because of his consistent positive expectation of me, I actually accomplish what he thought I could do even though I doubted myself.

His expectation for me to be strong is so high that times in the past in which some man was bullying me right in front of him (in two instances the men were pastors!) and I broke down crying, Robert would rebuke me afterwards . He would say something like, "Did you not know that man was trying to break you down and expose a weakness in you? Do not give into that manipulation! Do not cry in front of someone like that!" There was not even a little taste of "My poor little baby girl". He became a drill sergeant to me in times like that. I grew stronger under his direction. I am grateful. He literally wants me to be a strong woman.

The fact is that even though the Lord gave me the call first to start a church, I do not know if I would have had the strength and courage to do that if I did not have Robert as my husband at that time! I really needed him to help me come forth in my role.

Although I had a B.A.

“Letter from Rich Schrotenboer on doing devotional for class reunion. Said class theme is "God's Guidance" and would I lead a song too. That got me thinking about the many song's we could sing: Savior like a Shepherd lead us, where He leads me I will follow, We've come this far by Faith, oh God you are my God and I will ever…you,,, and step by step He will leaddd me.

Not long thereafter I discovered Wagner Leadership Institute (now Wagner University) and started taking courses. I did spend some time on campus in Colorado Springs; however, their teachers were holding meetings (mostly conventions) all over the country so I did not have to go there on campus throughout my schooling. About four years after starting that school I emerged with a doctorate of practical ministry.

My current jobs at church include doing most all of the pulpit ministry, training ministers in the in-house school, doing the TV program two Mondays a month, doing youth seminars, writing skits and getting people to do them, doing an annual children’s program (“Friends of Jesus”) , overseeing and performing most all the administrative work (I have 2 helpers), overseeing all educational programs in church, doing periodic counseling and/or crisis interventions, conducting weddings and funerals and baby dedications, preparing and chairing our board meetings (complete with bi annual finance reports) , doing all scheduling and putting it in a weekly bulletin, and , as you can imagine, many others things that come up from day to day.

The older I get the more *I sense the urgency of “redeeming the time” by doing kingdom work*. I am all too aware that it is only in my lifetime on earth that I can do this – once I die, the time on earth to do His work is over.

My husband and I do devotions together five days a week and thereby stay in close

fellowship with each other personally in the Lord. He is my pastor; he says I am his pastor. He is my co-pastor; I am his co-pastor. He is my biggest cheerleader, confidant, best friend, and precious husband. When we started out we were among many who said a woman could not be a pastor/teacher. Robert, my dear husband, withstood all that pressure from the outside that wanted him to prevent me from coming forth! I am so grateful the Lord gave him to me! He is very much a fatherly pastor to our flock and does teach now and again. (He is 78 now – when we started out we took turns in the pulpit and often taught as a team.) I am delighted when he is in the pulpit! He does remain in charge of all the music, praise, and worship. When I travel alone, he does the pulpit work. He is always willing to make sure I am free to go when a door is opened to minister.

We've come this far by faith

HIS PRESENCE IN TIMES OF TROUBLE HE IS STILL THERE

Hebrews 13:5-6 (KJV)
5 *Let your* conversation *be* without covetousness; *and be* content with such things as ye have: for he hath said, I will never leave thee, nor forsake thee.
6 So that we may boldly say, The Lord *is* my helper, and I will not fear what man shall do unto me.

He did nto bring me this far to leave me

If we cry out to Him in times of trouble with a trusting, loving heart, He will make a way for us out of our trouble

Song: God will make a way when there seems to be no way, He works in ways we cannot see, God will make a way for me.....

Psalm 91: 14 Because he hath set his love upon me, therefore will I deliver him: I will set him on high, because he hath known my name. **15 He shall call upon me, and I will answer him: I *will be* with him in trouble; I will deliver him, and honour him**. 16 With long life will I satisfy him, and shew him my salvation.

Isaiah 40: 28 Hast thou not known? hast thou not heard, *that* the everlasting God, the LORD, the Creator of the ends of the earth, fainteth not, neither is weary? *there is* no searching of his understanding.
29 He giveth power to the faint; and to *them that have* no might he increaseth strength.
30 Even the youths shall faint and be weary, and the young men shall utterly fall:
31 But they that wait upon the LORD shall renew *their* strength; they

shall mount up with wings as eagles; they shall run, and not be weary; *and* they shall walk, and not faint.

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I was in a place of very deep despair from around '6 9 to early '75. It was my own fault. Yet I cried out to God for deliverance. Pushing me into a place of patiently waiting on God knowing I had put in place all I knew todo. Stand. Trust God will do something.

When I was frequently singing the song, "I saw every tear drop when in darkness you cried, and I strove to remind you that for those tears I died", I sometimes stopped to think on how LONG I had been crying out to God for relief from the consequences of marrying wrongfully. I did start to understand spiritual warfare . Then there came the day I simply left and moved to California. While there God consistently provided.

Dad died. I returned. The first Sunday at Bethel Robert asked Shelley and I to his Bible study. God had a timing and a plan for me.

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We must make sure we have done all we must do on our part in order to be able to wait on God to do what He chooses to do on our behalf. He has given us weapons that enable us to stand our ground in victory:

Ephesians 6:13[13] Wherefore take unto you the whole armour of God, that ye may be able to withstand in the evil day, **and having done all, to stand.** [14] Stand therefore, having your loins girt about with truth, and having on the breastplate of righteousness; [15] And your feet shod with the preparation of the gospel of peace;
[16] Above all, taking the shield of faith, wherewith ye shall be able to quench all the fiery darts of the wicked.
[17] And take the helmet of salvation, and the sword of the Spirit, which is the word of God:
[18] Praying always with all prayer and supplication in the Spirit, and watching thereunto with all perseverance and supplication for all saints;
[19] And for me, that utterance may be given unto me, that I may open my mouth boldly, to make known the mystery of the gospel,
[20] For which I am an in bonds: that therein I may speak boldly, as I ought to speak.
[21] But that ye also may know my affairs, *and* how I do, Tychicus, a beloved brother and faithful minister in the Lord, shall make known to you all things: ambassador
[22] Whom I have sent unto you for the same purpose, that ye might know our affairs, and *that* he might comfort your hearts.
[23] Peace *be* to the brethren, and love with faith, from God the Father and the Lord Jesus Christ.

[24] Grace *be* with all them that love our Lord Jesus Christ in sincerity. Amen.

We wait on him with confident expectation that He will strengthen us:

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God's hand in directing our path unto good opportunities :

Stone's engetal--- met Doorns there….resulted in their coming to us numerous times, cementing relationships with handmaidens, Kingsway, White Horse.

Prophecy that encourages us to walk in paths set before us

Prophetic words: Bernard Jordan: tv and pack your suitcase to travel

Within a short time tct tv called and also we went up to Marquette and ended in basement of bouncing betty

FINANCES AS A PART OF GOD'S DIRECTION

3500 for mission trip

31.99 in cash in mail right after that was my exact expenditure for mailings for first rol meeting.

We get kicked out of house; I mention it to ken van loo he is deacon at Shawnee. Frank gill gives 1500 that is what we used as downpaymenet to sylvan.

Susie gives rol her sound system.

Sylvan: tried hard to sell…than saw daVid at 700 to him and we had an agreement

Dennis brown at tct tv …I told him we would buy kbldg

Division bldg. rj sold on street with a handshake

Sale from 12th st enabled us to get leonard st.

Someone once prophesied we'd get this bldg….gantos…on s division and I had no faith for that. What we have now is way more valuable than that!!

The trumpets too indicated that God will provide with or without ourk faith1!

God impresses Word and Vision on our hearts in connection with His calling on our life:

Evolution of our church: after ca. in my own pers bible studies, I began to see ephe 4 as a model for doing church. Also I had a drem about looking for an Emmanuel house. Clearly I was longing for something that I had not yet seen.

Actually back in 71 I was a member at grace crc and began to wonder/ask why we were so far behind acts. Carla ne weidenaar came to me one day and said she thought she heard about what I was looking for. Meetings at st mary's catholic church. Went. Took loie/cal. Amazing and yes this was some of the picture of what I wanted. After that deeper life tablernacle…john woods….then co workders…neither Christians. Heard ofk good music at bethel…..2 conseutive weeks I went with them…I cried the whole time. The 3rd week I went alone. I went after that faithfully until I left for California.l the choir r

eally ministered to me. Abney's hang in there God will come through sermons did too. James abney still a close friend today. I took cal there…later I brought him in to teach at 200 madison….

Midweek I went at that time to meetings at bergsma's. I watched their journey from a Grandville crc to maranatha. I saw extremem faith at work. They took me in a coupled of times when my life was in jeorpardy.

Church: rj and I serarched for a eph 4 church. We went through betherl, maranatha, a time of apartness when we did prayer at 700 club, bible studies in our home, and ministered at juvy…..then first assembly. In our apart time I saw a n inner vision of a plant thqt was takien out of a pot with dirt and put into a glass of water to let its roots be there for awhaile …I knew it was going to be place in dirt again to al y stable and flourish.

Divine connections; divine favor – the results can be open doors for ministry

Robert and I visited first assembly and Robert said to me that this was to be our church home. It was definitely not my idea. But what is interesting is that when I got the baptism in the Spirit several years before, ie.. the spring of 72, it was on 44th exactly where first was later built. Still later, while in benson's office I saw the charter member plaque and on it were some of my hoyt and Fairbairn relatives!! At first assembly; we received immediate favor with benson. He put us into the foyer to recruit for the c/c class.

God has always sent in the peope. Loie told us in the beginning: don't beg anyone to come nor to stay.

got married 10 8

Since that time t/t became missionaries and have come to minister at ROL many times. Also, I have been once to the Dominican Republic to minister there.

Starting River of Life What's that in your hand, Moses? God telling us to start a church and to name it rol….the song…..so in 12 79 metg of s and first week of 80 strted church. I was still at social services at that time . It so happenekd that we were

switching to having all the client's stats online. So we workders had to stop all of our usual work to go through the tedious process of uploading all the stats. For whatever reason that uploading had quite a few minutes of just waiting etween various data entry times.

Trouble used of God:Not having my luggage in 2010 belgium trip:spending time in hosptital studying Jacob and deciding I did want to live…used

Encounter at airport …favoe to look in warehouse after a time of discussing the Lord

Running in desperation to san diego but meeting the stilwells there

Having blood clots and going through a marriage crisis resulting in husbans deliverance (Kelly varner…little boy spirit…. Long talks, greater intimacy, a breaking of his not wanting to face things…..)

Breast cancer…county had program for Medicaid….broken arm in ny city paid for too… new jersey heaven on earth love that taught me He can take care of me anywhere… driving home and asking people to start my car…… Those

Trust God/love/forgive people

A dear friend cutting me loose and a new (after more than a year of grief processing) understanding of guarding my heart against putting too much power in relationships. Being willing afterwards to do a wider spread of my arms to include all sent to me and not relying on anyone or any group to be my safe place of warmth and acceptance. Being able to take rejection a lot better / learning to stand on my own 2 feet without needing others to understand when I believe I am right and have done nothing to cause the rejection. Knowing that false acusations are part of the persecution. Learning to geniu=uinely love and forgive even if the misunderstanding/rejection persists. To learn to bless them in prayer and be happy if I hear of their being blessed. To totally release others to the Lord.

The first time I vividly remember experiencing unfair criticism is when I discerned strong dishonor towards me. I had no idea what was actually going on. So I said in the pulpit: We never ask for the double honor the Word says we should get; however, I will not accept double dishonor. It was not long after that I found out that some ladies were meeting together to discuss what to do about the fasecret meeting about my supposed misue was a farce brought on by ignorance of what I was legally allowed Su do. ct I had used church money to purchase some dishes to be used when we had ministry guests over because I had rather mismateched stuff to use until I got those very moderately priced new dishes. The fact is that I could have bought them freely out of our housing allowance for personal use so the I whole v\farce of the secret gossip session were birthed out of their ignorance of the law regarding housing allowances for pastors. I have no idea what inspired them to be up in arms about this; however I do know that bringing the issue into

the light made it all blow away like smoke in the wind.

Ask the Pastor: When I started doing Ask the pastor in the nineties, I was one of only a few women pastors asked to be on there. I waexperience I would come home and tell my husband about things that were said that got to me.. My husband had no sympathy whatevs invited to be on by the station e key point is to simply do the work of the Lord and ignore the opposition. I must be confident in my calling and the ability gained the respect and acceptance of nearly all my co workers on that tv program. program. In the first years I could feel the resistance from some. One guy actually said on live tv , "should we let her answer"?? When there was a question on whether a wife should have to submit to her husband or whether a woman could be a pastor, usually they would look at me to see how I responded personally to the question or joke about giving me the question. In the first years of this I would go home and tell Robert about various things that "got to me" . He had NO sympathy for me. He did then and still makes a demand on me to be strong and not moved by anything that people do to try to hold me back or trip me up. He has been a huge help in my becoming stronger and stronger as a minister! The Lord told me finally…in a still small voice instide….to just do the work and never mind their attitudes towards women in a pastor al role. He said that as I do it in excellence they will respect me for the works' say and the controversy over my right to be there would fade away. That is exactly what happened. After a bit over 25 years of service I had become simply one of the many pasotrs a

With no special attention given to the fact I was a woman. In fact, they had me host the program many , many times an honor I did not see go to any other woman. I was grateful for the vote of confidence given me during that season.

If we can consider shame over our own failures and bad choices as part of suffering, then I will also introduce the fact that I had acted very badly as a wild child in partying in the mid sixties culminating in a San Francisco stint in 1968 as a hippie getting high daily on marijuana and running around with just about any crowd or individual that I thought would give me a 'good" time. I BROUGHT WORRY and

Joseph: what the devil meant for evil……

….also, SWIM with its door to door and vbs…..I remember entering into albuquerque with fear because I suddenly realized I knew nothing!!1

Learning to discern God's guidance in making choices:

Prophetic words: how they gave me courage to say "yes" to various activities.

My tewt points of action: peace, husband's green liglht, financial ability to respond. Things out of my control: who would ask me to come and do something. EG gatsi's invite to zim…money there, peace, husband fine, my desire to minister there when I got

into zim, the airport experience….esp the mama te te dress during the time they searched my luggage

Hub

Esther king called and asked me to be here aglow vp. I was at 301 burton at the food counter when she called. I remember leaning on my elbows thinking"If she finds out I am divorced and remarried, she will not want me: …so I told her and it did not phase her at all

In the mid 70'a the Spanish group led to phillpe led to neznajko

88 at engeltal led to doorns led to roget led to kamuangas

Fransisca:

vbs even sarted she got a call from ricardo Villanueva…now we have exchanged pulpits.

Dennis susan: local minister's mtg…they took us to Detroit yoder mtgs with hammon and we got huge prophetic words…the one about prophecying to all in room led me to have the courage to do that.

Coming home from san diego at dad's death…shelly/bethel/Robert….

Robert: first assembly: benson asked us to do college and career…Susie….. fern….

Stilwell; looked in phone book rather randomly,,,,ended up at their home mother's day 1975,,,,chuck susan dinner mom's day, live with stilwell. He ff'd me to Emmanuel house…..after lived with Barbara…..then she said go and other lady had just said to live with her….dad died I came home.whi

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While at calvin, looked at employment opportunities for students: found juvy. Via juvy met birth mom. Met sisters one by one…ministered to all 4 and to mom.

Via juvy via looking for betsy stubbs, went to 1400 madison…j"here is our ride to the roller rink. Louie never made it into the roller rink. From there on in we talked almost nightly on the road by his home at 600 Jefferson se. I thought he was way younger and also never thought of him as permanent until I found I wanted to be with him whenever I could be. Then wanted to break up but too late…..went off to san fran but he came and got me. Son….now l is saved.

The birth papers I saw at juvy reassuring me God had my back all along

The vision of jesus coming intot he room to carry me out to herms….dad herms verse

“when your mom and dad forsake, the Lord…..:

The vbs teacher when I was 8 :God has given you a beautiful voice”; papa doorn at viewing”You 2 harmonize beautifully together

My dream of playing piano for a pastor husband.

Orphanage/teacher/missionary

My awareness that my place would not be crc/dutch

The night louie put the 38 t0 my head and I ran out in the snow on bates…around 1 am… flagged down a car that just happened to take me to Gaylen/sam….Jesus Christ superstar, who are you who do you say you are

Crying out for a christian friend – meeting loie at roger’s plaza…her calling ruth several weeks later, got mom’s number and then mine. She called on a day I stayed home depressed with suicidal thoughts.

She startedto study on deliverance. She decided I needed it and I said no way. Soon thereafter blackie came to my work and I said “Go to h…” to him. In anger it poured out of my mouth. Then I knew I did need deliverance. Loie and Cal in the barn ministering to me…..many subsequent to that

Prophetiss strain and then me going back for more deliverance.

Lots from rejection…occult…..mary mom into that

Mary mom went to fortturne tellwer while I was in her womb.

Rejection, adultery: Hobart freeman

Hold me daddy Robert at kathy’s house.

Pagan ryhythym…..from hippie days

Linda sutter: rejection deliverance

Since then I too have cast demons out of many.

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Crying out for a Christian friend

Deliverances:

Whiskey Joe’s : We always sit on deck by water…this time EG said for us to go on the sand portion on the ground by the water. EG sat with us for a couple of hours and then left in his own car. When EG left Robert and I kissed each other.

It started raining. We went over and sat on bar stools because it was covered there. A lady came over to us and asked how long we had been married and said it made her happy when she saw us kiss each other. Quickly we went from one thing to another and ended up praying for her to get the baptism in the Spirit which she said she wanted. We are going to send her HAGIN'S book on "Why Tongues".

The "When peace like a river " at Bob's funeral and the "Tis so Sweet to trust in Jesus" at Mama doorn's viewing

The checking out of hospice and linda just happened to be standing by the window

Gregory at the pool we go to his dad's church. The preacher says that sometimes when you think there is a period, God has a comma; God has you on pause. I shared that statement with EG…he looked surprise because that is exactly what his boss told him: I am putting you on pause.

I could tell that EG saw that God was in me sharing that with him. II has been EG's frustration that he Sar hears God directly . EG saw clearly that God had us in fla to be there for papa doorn.

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Do a chapter on music and songs

Deliverance chapter

Racism chapter

Divine connections

Ministry trips

Political fervor

"Don't beg anyone to come; Don't beg anyone to stay

The churches we pastored ; the school we did; the pastors we busted;

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